EVERYDAY SKILL

AI Prompt Cheat Sheets

Ask better questions. Get more useful answers.

A plain-English toolkit for getting useful work out of an AI assistant, without memorizing magic words.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 The five parts of a clear prompt
02 Everyday prompts that earn their keep
03 Tutors, editors, and thinking partners
04 A repair guide for weak answers
05 A blank prompt planner

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

The five parts of a clear prompt

A prompt is just a request with enough context to be useful. You do not need secret phrases. You need to tell the AI what you are trying to do, what it should know, and what a good answer looks like.

The five slots

01 **Goal:** Name the outcome. “Help me prepare for a meeting” is clearer than “work stuff.”

02 **Context:** Add the who, what, and why. A little real detail beats a long vague story.

03 **Materials:** Paste the notes or name the source you want it to use — and tell it not to add outside facts.

04 **Format:** Ask for a table, five bullets, a 150-word draft, a checklist, or a step-by-step plan.

05 **Boundaries:** Say what to avoid, what not to invent, and what to do when it is unsure.

PROMPT RECIPE — THE ALL-PURPOSE STARTER

```
Help me [goal].
Here’s what’s going on: [context].
Use this material: [paste notes or name your source].
Give me: [format and length].
Keep it [tone]. Don’t [boundary].
If anything important is missing, ask me up to three questions before you start.
```

PROMPT RECIPE — WEAK: TOO LITTLE TO WORK WITH

```
Write about meal planning.
```

PROMPT RECIPE — STRONGER: ENOUGH TO HELP

```
I need five weeknight dinners for two people who eat
vegetarian.
We’re okay with leftovers, but not mushrooms, and we have
about
25 minutes to cook. Give me a table of meals, then a
shopping list
grouped by grocery section. Ask before assuming we own
special tools.
```

TRY THIS

One line that improves most prompts

“Ask me up to three questions if anything important is missing.” It brings back the missing detail without turning the task into a twenty-message interrogation. Not every prompt needs all five slots — but the brackets are where the usefulness lives.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

Everyday prompts that earn their keep

These are the ones worth taping to the fridge. Swap the bracketed details for your real situation, then delete anything that does not fit.

PROMPT RECIPE — EXPLAIN IT PLAINLY

Explain [topic] in plain English for someone who [context]. Use one everyday analogy, then walk me through it in five short steps. Put any term that needs defining in bold. Keep it under 250 words.

PROMPT RECIPE — TURN A MESS INTO A SUMMARY

Turn the notes below into (1) a five-bullet summary, (2) a separate “Decisions” list, and (3) a “Next actions” list with an owner for each. Do not add facts that aren’t in the notes.

Notes: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — FIND THE FIRST STEP

I feel stuck with [task] because [why]. Ask me up to three questions, then give me a 20-minute first step, a one-hour version, and a low-energy version. Do not give me a twelve-step plan.

PROMPT RECIPE — COMPARE WITHOUT THE HYPE

Help me choose between [A], [B], and [C]. My priorities are [priority one] and [priority two]. My constraints are [time, budget, energy]. Make a simple comparison table, name the trade-offs, and recommend the option that fits my priorities — not the one that sounds most impressive.

PROMPT RECIPE — REHEARSE A HARD CONVERSATION

Role-play a conversation where I need to [say no / ask for help / set a boundary] with [person and relationship]. Be realistic, not a pushover. Start with the other person’s likely reaction. After each of my replies, respond as they might, then give me one short coaching note. Stay in the scene until I type END.

GOOD TO KNOW

A good prompt is a conversation starter

You are allowed — encouraged, even — to say “That’s not it. Try again, but shorter and less cheerful.” The first answer is a draft of the request, not a verdict on your idea.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

Turn the AI into a tutor

A useful tutor does not simply talk at you. It finds out what you know, makes you produce something, and points to the next small gap. These prompts set that up.

PROMPT RECIPE — TUTOR, DON'T TELL

Be my tutor for [topic]. Don't explain everything at once. Ask me one question at a time, starting with something I already know. Wait for my answer. If I'm wrong, give me a hint before the explanation. After five questions, give me a one-page recap.

PROMPT RECIPE — QUIZ ME PROPERLY

Make a ten-question quiz on [topic] for someone at [level]. Mix recall, application, and one tricky question. Ask one question at a time and wait. Don't show the answers until I'm done. Then explain the ones I missed.

PROMPT RECIPE — GRADE MY EXPLANATION

I'll explain [concept] in my own words. Grade it for accuracy and clarity on a 1–5 scale. Name one thing I got right, one gap, and one small next question I should be able to answer. Don't rewrite it for me yet.

My explanation: [paste]

Use a source, not just a summary

Paste your course notes, cite the book, or name the article. Then add: "If the source doesn't cover something, say so instead of filling the gap." AI can explain a topic beautifully and still sand off the one detail that matters. Your source keeps the conversation grounded.

TRY THIS

The test of a good study session

Could you now explain the idea without the chat window open? If not, ask for another round of questions — not another summary. Retrieval beats rereading.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

Prompts for work and writing

These are drafts, not decisions. Read them aloud, check every date and promise, and keep the parts that sound like a person you would trust.

PROMPT RECIPE — THE EMAIL THAT GETS TO THE POINT

Rewrite the draft email below for clarity and warmth. Keep it under [number] words, preserve every commitment and date, and give me a subject line. Don’t make it stiff or add claims I didn’t make.

Draft: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — SHORTEN WITHOUT FLATTENING

Cut this to [length] while keeping the facts, the specific examples, and my voice. Put any phrase you removed in a list below the edit so I can decide what to restore.

Text: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — NOTES INTO ACTIONS

Turn these meeting notes into: (1) decisions, (2) open questions, (3) action items with an owner and due date if stated, and (4) anything I should verify. Do not assign an owner or deadline that isn’t in the notes.

Notes: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — A HARD MESSAGE, HANDLED WITH CARE

Help me write a [number]-sentence message to [person or role] about [issue]. State the situation plainly, avoid blame, and include a specific next step. Give me two versions: direct and gentle. Don’t invent an apology or a promise.

Facts: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — MAKE A PROCESS REPEATABLE

Turn this process into a one-page checklist a new person could follow: [describe or paste the steps]. Number every step, call out tools or warnings, and flag anything I left ambiguous instead of guessing.

WATCH OUT

Keep the judgment in the room

Do not paste confidential workplace information into an unapproved tool. If the work involves health, legal, HR, money, or other people’s private data, check your employer’s policy first. You are still the author of anything you send.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

Prompts for authors and small shops

AI can help you see your own work from a reader's angle. It should not invent credentials, write fake reviews, or promise results you cannot prove. Use it to clarify, not to impersonate.

PROMPT RECIPE — READER-FIRST OUTLINE

I'm writing a [type of book or guide] for [reader] who is [situation]. They want [outcome], but they're worried about [fear]. Suggest three possible structures. For each: the promise, the chapter arc, and a strong first chapter. Ask me three questions before you commit to an outline. Avoid generic advice.

PROMPT RECIPE — STRESS-TEST THE BLURB

Here is my book description: [paste]. Tell me what a tired reader understands in ten seconds, what's vague, and what sounds like every other book in this category. Then give me two tightened versions: warm and direct. Don't invent endorsements, credentials, or sales numbers.

PROMPT RECIPE — EXPLORE TITLES HONESTLY

Brainstorm fifteen titles for [project] about [core idea] for [reader]. Use these tones: [warm, practical, bold]. Flag accidental clichés and anything that overpromises. Then pick three and explain the trade-off in one line each — don't just tell me what I want to hear.

PROMPT RECIPE — A LISTING THAT SAYS WHAT IT IS

Turn these product details into a clear listing for [platform]: [details]. Lead with the outcome for the buyer, include what's inside, who it's for, and a plain "what it isn't" line. Keep my voice. Don't invent reviews, guarantees, or results.

PROMPT RECIPE — TURN REAL QUESTIONS INTO USEFUL CONTENT

Here are real questions customers ask me: [paste]. Group them by theme and suggest eight short content pieces that answer them plainly. For each, give a hook, the one useful idea, and a soft next step. No fake urgency and no engagement bait.

GOOD TO KNOW

Your byline comes with your responsibility

AI can make a weak promise sound polished. You are still the one accountable for accuracy, copyright, claims, and tone. Reject anything that makes your reader feel tricked into buying.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

Ask for evidence, not applause

AI is very good at sounding confident. A useful assistant can be right and wrong in the same paragraph. These prompts make it show its work, name uncertainty, and separate facts from guesses.

PROMPT RECIPE — SOURCE-GROUNDED BRIEF

Using only the source below, make a one-page brief: the main claim, three supporting facts, one contradiction or tension, and what's missing. Quote short phrases for each fact. If the source doesn't answer something, write "not stated."

Source: [paste]

PROMPT RECIPE — STEELMAN THE OTHER SIDE

I currently believe [position] about [issue]. Steelman the best case against it, then the best case for it. Label facts versus interpretations. Finish by naming the one piece of evidence that would most change the picture.

PROMPT RECIPE — CHECK THIS CLAIM

Here is a claim I want to check: [claim]. Break it into separate factual claims. For each, tell me: (a) what would count as evidence, (b) how I could verify it with an official or primary source, (c) your confidence, and (d) what you might be missing. Do not invent citations or links.

PROMPT RECIPE — UNCERTAINTY FIRST

Before answering [question], list what you don't know, what is likely to change, and what could make your answer wrong. Then answer, and keep those uncertainties visible in a note at the end.

PROMPT RECIPE — A DECISION MATRIX

Help me compare [options]. Ask for my criteria and their weights before scoring if I haven't given them. Then make a simple table with a confidence note for each score. Separate facts from judgment. Finish with a recommendation and one question I should ask a human expert.

WATCH OUT

A citation is not proof

If an AI gives you links, open them and read them. If it gives you a fact that matters, confirm it with a primary or official source — or with a person who actually knows. A plausible URL can still be wrong, dead, or about something else entirely.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 01

When the answer misses

You do not have to start over. Name what went wrong, keep what worked, and ask for a specific change. Most weak answers improve with one honest follow-up.

WHAT WENT WRONG	WHAT TO SAY NEXT
Too vague or generic	“Give me three specific versions, each with a concrete example and a different trade-off.”
Too long or padded	“Cut this by half without losing facts. Put anything you removed in a list below.”
Not in my voice	“List the five phrases that sound least like me, propose replacements, then rewrite only those sections.”
Invented details	“Mark every factual claim as verified, inferred, or unknown. Rewrite using only verified claims.”
Ignored a limit	“Restate the task and my constraints in one sentence. Tell me which constraint you missed.”
Too agreeable	“Argue against my idea for one paragraph. Make the strongest honest case, not a straw man.”

PROMPT RECIPE — THE CLEAN RESTART

Let’s restart this cleanly.
What I want: [goal].
What I actually need: [specific output].
The context you were missing: [details].
Keep: [what worked].
Avoid: [what didn’t].
Before answering, summarize the task in one sentence and ask me up to two questions.

Build one you can reuse

Open a note called “My prompts.” Save the version you actually used, not a perfect version you never tried. Add one line about what you would change next time.

TRY THIS

A prompt is not a performance

Short and clear beats long and clever. If you would feel strange reading the prompt out loud to a colleague, make it simpler.

ONE LAST THING · 01

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Pick one prompt from this guide, use it on a real task today, and edit it until the wording sounds like you.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

Use AI like a useful first draft — not a final authority. Keep your judgment, check the facts, and protect private information.

More AI printables

- 02 Beginner AI Glossary
- 03 AI Privacy Checklist
- 04 AI for Job Search
- 05 AI for Budgeting
- 06 The 7-Day AI Learning Challenge

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.

PLAIN-ENGLISH REFERENCE

Beginner AI Glossary

The words, minus the fog.

A pocket reference for the AI conversation you keep finding yourself in — without pretending you already speak the language.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 A model is not a brain
02 The words inside a chat window
03 Agents, tools, and local AI
04 Privacy, safety, and trust
05 How to decode a sales pitch

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

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PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 02

Start with the big picture

AI is an umbrella term, not one product. Most of the tools in today's headlines are pattern machines: they learn from huge collections of examples, then produce a likely answer. That can be genuinely useful. It can also be wrong with a straight face.

A model is not a brain

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **The most useful mental model**
>
> A language model is closer to an extremely well-read autocomplete than to a person with intentions. It predicts likely words, sounds, and patterns from what it has seen. It does not understand consequences the way you do.

The four-step story

01 **Collect examples.** Training data is gathered and prepared — text, images, audio, code, or records.

02 **Find patterns.** Training changes millions or billions of internal numbers called parameters.

03 **Save the pattern.** The result is a model: a learned system that can make predictions.

04 **Use the pattern.** When you type a prompt, inference produces an output. The model is being used, not newly educated.

The foundational words

Artificial intelligence (AI)
Computer systems built to do tasks that usually require human judgment, like recognizing an image or drafting text. AI is a broad label, not one thing.

Machine learning
A way of building software where a system learns patterns from examples instead of following only hand-written rules.

Generative AI
AI that creates new text, images, audio, video, or code by predicting patterns from earlier examples. New output is not automatically original or accurate.

Inference
The moment a trained model produces an answer. In a normal chat, inference is use — not permanent learning.

Chatbot
A conversational interface for a model. It can feel like a person while remaining software that predicts a likely response.

Algorithm
A defined set of steps for solving a problem. A recipe is a useful analogy. AI algorithms can adjust from examples, but they are still procedures.

Model
The learned pattern-matcher saved after training. In everyday use, "the model" is the part of a tool that turns your input into a prediction.

Training data
The examples used to teach a model. Quality, gaps, and bias in this data shape what the model can do and where it fails.

Parameters
The internal numerical settings adjusted during training. More parameters can add capability, but bigger does not automatically mean better.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 02

The words inside a chat window

When someone says “the model has a two-million-token context window,” this is the vocabulary they are using. You do not need to memorize it. You need enough to ask a good follow-up question.

Large language model (LLM)
A model trained on large amounts of text to predict what comes next. That simple objective supports drafting, summarizing, explaining, and translating — with mistakes.

Context window
The amount of text and conversation a model can consider at one time. When it fills up, older material may be dropped or compressed. Think working memory, not a permanent file.

System prompt
Instructions set by the app or developer that sit above your message. You usually cannot see or change them, and they can govern tone, rules, and tools.

Hallucination
A confident-sounding output that is fabricated or wrong. The model is not lying on purpose; it is generating something plausible. Verify names, numbers, quotes, and links.

Fine-tuning
Extra training on examples to shape behavior or style. It is not a reliable database, and specialization does not guarantee accuracy.

Embedding
A numerical representation of meaning. Embeddings help software find text or images that are conceptually similar, powering search and RAG.

Token
A chunk of text, roughly part of a word, that a model processes. Tokens drive context limits, speed, and sometimes the price of an API.

Prompt
The instructions, examples, and context you give the model. A prompt is a request with boundaries, not a magic spell.

Temperature
A setting that influences randomness. Lower values tend to be more predictable; higher values can be more varied. It has nothing to do with emotion.

Knowledge cutoff
The point after which a model’s training data roughly stops. Without browsing or live data, it may not know recent events or changed rules.

Retrieval-augmented generation (RAG)
The tool finds relevant documents first, then gives them to the model as context. Useful for grounding — but the model can still misread or misuse the source.

Multimodal
Able to work with more than one kind of input or output — text, images, audio, and so on. Check which modes a specific tool actually supports.

TRY THIS

What “memory” usually means

A chat window may remember the current conversation. A product may also store details across chats as a memory feature. Neither is the same as the underlying model permanently learning from you during a normal conversation.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 02

When AI gets tools

A chat model can only produce tokens. An AI product can do much more when it is connected to search, files, calendars, code, or payment systems. The vocabulary here is mostly about permission.

Agent

An AI system given a goal, tools, and permission to take multiple steps — not just answer once. More autonomy means more chances for costly or harmful actions, so check what it can access.

Function calling

A structured way for a model to request a specific tool action with specific arguments. It helps software connect the model to real operations.

API

Application Programming Interface: a way for one piece of software to talk to another. APIs let builders put models inside their own apps and workflows.

Local AI

Running a model on your own device rather than sending requests to a cloud service. It can improve privacy and offline access, but hardware, speed, and quality are limited.

Quantization

A technique for compressing a model to use less memory and run on smaller hardware. It can reduce quality, so compare outputs rather than assuming parity.

Tool use

When a model can call something outside itself, such as a calculator, search, or calendar. Without a connected tool, it is generating an answer, not checking one.

Model Context Protocol (MCP)

An open standard for connecting AI applications to data and tools through a common interface. Think shared adapter, not automatic safety. Each connection still needs review.

Workflow automation

Using software to run a series of steps without manual effort. Automation may use rules, AI, or both; every automatic step deserves a stop button and a way to check results.

Open weights

A model whose trained parameters can be downloaded and run. “Open weights” does not necessarily mean the training data, code, or license is open — or that the model is unrestricted.

VRAM

Memory on a graphics card (GPU). Local models need it to run smoothly; too little can mean slower work or a model that will not fit.

WATCH OUT

The more access, the more verification

An agent that can read your email, change files, or spend money is a different risk from a chat box that can only talk. Start with read-only access, limit the tools, and put a human in front of irreversible actions.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 02

Privacy, safety, and trust

This is not the scary chapter. It is the practical one. You do not need to become a security researcher; you need to know which words describe which risks, and where to look.

Personally identifiable information (PII)
Data that can identify a person directly or in combination: names, addresses, ID numbers, contact details, and sometimes seemingly ordinary details.

Training opt-out
A setting that stops a service from using your content to improve its models, where offered. It usually does not erase past history; check deletion separately.

Guardrail
A product rule or filter meant to prevent certain harmful outputs or actions. Guardrails reduce risk; they do not eliminate it.

Jailbreak
A prompt or trick that gets around a model's safeguards. Treat a jailbroken answer as evidence of a flaw, not as permission or reliable truth.

Watermark
A visible or hidden signal suggesting content was made by AI. Watermarks can be removed, missed, or faked, so treat them as clues rather than proof.

AI slop
Low-effort synthetic content produced at scale. It can crowd search results, marketplaces, and social feeds, making source quality harder to judge.

Data retention
How long a service stores your chats, files, or account data. Deleting a conversation may not immediately remove copies from backups or logs.

Prompt injection
Hidden instructions in content — a web page, document, or email — that try to override what the user or developer intended. It matters most when an AI can browse, open files, or take actions.

Alignment
The broad effort to make AI systems behave in line with human intentions and values. It is an unsolved research and product problem, not a finished feature.

Deepfake
Synthetic audio, images, or video made to look like a real person or event. Public images and voice recordings can become raw material for deception.

Benchmark
A standardized test used to compare AI systems. Scores can help, but they may not reflect your real task, and benchmarks can be gamed or saturated.

GOOD TO KNOW

"Safety" is a claim to inspect

Ask which harms a product is protecting against, what its testing actually measured, and what a human can review. "Built-in safety" is not a synonym for "safe in every situation."

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 02

Decode the sales pitch

The AI label tells you almost nothing about whether a product is useful, private, or honest. These translations can help you ask better questions than “Is it AI?”

YOU’LL HEAR	WHAT IT MIGHT ACTUALLY MEAN
“AI-powered”	Some part uses machine learning or automation. Ask what it does that a simpler tool could not do, and what happens when it is wrong.
“Private and secure”	Not a technical guarantee. Look for retention terms, training controls, encryption, and who can access your content.
“Open source”	Check the license, weights, code, and data separately. Open weights alone do not make the whole product open source.
“Agentic”	It can take actions through tools. Find out which actions, with what permissions, and whether a human approves them.
“Reasoning model”	Designed for more deliberate processing. It can still be wrong, and may be slower or more expensive.
“Personalized”	Uses your history, memory, or data to shape results. Find out what is stored and how to clear it.
“Hallucination-free”	A marketing claim, not a guarantee. No current system is error-free, especially on facts, numbers, and citations.

Three questions for any AI claim

01 **What does it do on a normal Tuesday?** Ask for a specific task, not a polished demo.

02 **What data does it need — and keep?** Include everything you would be revealing in the input.

03 **How would I catch it being wrong?** If there is no way to check, the workflow is too fragile.

PROMPT RECIPE — LEARN ANY NEW AI TERM

I’m a beginner learning about AI. Explain [term] in plain English with: one analogy, one real-world example, one way it can fail, and one related term I should know. Define any jargon you use. If the definition depends on a specific product, say so.

TRY THIS

Fluency is not the goal

You do not need to sound impressive. You need to understand enough to decide when a tool is useful, when it is guessing, and when the answer needs a human with actual responsibility.

ONE LAST THING · 02

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Choose five terms you could not have explained this morning, then explain them out loud without using jargon. That is the real test.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

Use AI like a useful first draft — not a final authority. Keep your judgment, check the facts, and protect private information.

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.

PRIVACY & SAFETY

AI Privacy Checklist

Share less. Check more. Breathe easier.

A short, repeatable privacy routine for the AI tools you actually use — including the part most checklists skip: what to do after a mistake.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 The pause before you paste
02 The ten-minute account checkup
03 A safer look at connected tools
04 Work and healthcare boundaries
05 A plan for “I shared too much”

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
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PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

Before you paste

Most AI privacy problems do not start with a hacker. They start with a helpful person pasting something private into a box that felt like a conversation. Use this page as a pause button.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **The billboard test**
>
> If it would bother you to see this on a billboard with your name attached, do not paste it into a general consumer AI tool without a real reason, an approved tool, and a plan to redact.

Sort the information first

Usually fine

Public policies, product manuals, your own non-sensitive brainstorming, generic recipes, and anonymized category totals.

Still check copyright and platform terms before republishing what an AI generates.

Slow down

Your contact details, calendar specifics, drafts about identifiable people, unfinished work, personal photos, and location details.

Ask: do I need this exact detail for the task? Use a placeholder if not.

Stop and rethink

Government IDs, financial account numbers, passwords or API keys, patient and client records, private images of other people, and confidential legal or HR documents.

Use an approved tool, a qualified human, or a safer process.

Red is not a permanent “never.” It means this data carries real consequences: do not put it into a general-purpose tool without authorization, minimization, and a clear need.

The four-question pause

- ☐ **Need:** Is this exact detail necessary for the task?
- ☐ **Eyes:** Would I be okay if a coworker, client, or family member saw it?
- ☐ **Others:** Does this include someone else’s private information or story?
- ☐ **Permission:** Am I allowed to use this tool for this kind of data?

If any answer is no, redact it, replace it with a placeholder, or stop. A slightly less specific prompt is almost always better than a privacy cleanup later.

INSTEAD OF	TRY
A real name, phone, or email	[client], [family member], [email]
An account or card number	[account], [last four only]
A full address or workplace	[small town], [large employer]
A confidential project name	[new product], [internal project]

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

The ten-minute account checkup

Menu labels move around. Look for the behavior, not the exact words. Useful sections are often called Privacy, Data controls, Data & privacy, Personalization, Memory, Connected apps, or Security.

Data and history

- ☐ **Find the training control.** If the service lets you opt out of using chats to improve models, choose that. It usually affects future content, not what is already stored.
- ☐ **Review your history.** Delete conversations and uploaded files that contain sensitive information. Emptying a chat may not erase backup copies immediately.
- ☐ **Use temporary chats when offered.** They are useful for one-off questions you do not want saved in your main history.
- ☐ **Clear memory and personalization.** Remove stored details you do not want the tool to reuse — names, preferences, projects, or health details.
- ☐ **Check shared conversations.** Turn off link sharing and revoke old links that may still work.
- ☐ **Download your data if you need a record.** Keep it somewhere private, and remember that a full export is itself sensitive.

Access and account security

- ☐ **Remove unfamiliar connected apps, plugins, or connectors.** Look for anything with access to email, files, calendars, or accounts.
- ☐ **Check mobile permissions.** Does the app really need your contacts, microphone, photos, or files? Limit anything that is not needed.
- ☐ **Review browser extensions.** Remove AI add-ons and extensions you do not use, especially ones that can read and change every page.
- ☐ **Use a unique password and multi-factor authentication.** Prefer a passkey or authenticator app over text-message codes when possible.
- ☐ **Separate work and personal accounts.** This limits what gets mixed together when you switch contexts.
- ☐ **Repeat the pass quarterly.** Settings change, features appear, and old permissions linger. A recurring calendar reminder is the whole trick.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **Delete is not always gone**
>
> A chat can be removed from your screen while copies remain in backups, logs, or a service's records for a period defined in its policy. Delete what you can, opt out where offered, and prevent the next paste instead of promising yourself the perfect cleanup.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

Connected tools need a second look

A connector can read your files, send email, post to a calendar, or act in an app for you. That convenience is also an expansion of what can go wrong. Permission is not consent forever.

Before you connect anything

- ☐ **What can it read?** Name the actual data: one file, all email, a calendar, a customer database.
- ☐ **What can it write or do?** Reading is not the same as sending, deleting, purchasing, or posting publicly.
- ☐ **Whose data is included?** Your files may contain other people's messages, health details, or work secrets.
- ☐ **Where does the data go?** Is it processed in the cloud, kept for how long, and used to improve a model?
- ☐ **How do I revoke it?** Find the off switch before you connect, and know whether removing the app also deletes past data.
- ☐ **Is there a lower-access option?** Paste one redacted excerpt instead of connecting the whole drive.

Start lower on the ladder

RUNG	WHAT IT MEANS	SAFER DEFAULT
One	You type a question in a chat	Keep sensitive details out
Two	The AI reads one document you choose	Remove names and account numbers
Three	The AI can search email, files, or calendar	Use a work-approved tool; limit scope
Four	The AI can write, send, post, or delete	Require review before action
Five	The AI can spend money or change access	Keep a human approval step every time

TRY THIS

Matches on the web are not instructions

A web page or document can contain hidden directions aimed at an AI assistant. If a tool can browse or read files, treat outside content as untrusted — especially when the tool can also take actions.

Local-first is a direction, not a halo

Running a model on your own computer can reduce what leaves your device. It does not automatically make a workflow private. The browser extension, synced notes app, backup service, or screen recorder around it may still collect data. Ask the same four questions: what goes in, what is stored, who can see it, and how do I remove it?

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

At work and in healthcare

Work information belongs to more than one person. A policy exists because a mistake can affect a patient, customer, employee, or the organization you work for. “Everyone uses AI” is not the same as “you are allowed to use this tool for this data.”

Before using AI for work

- ☐ **Check the approved-tools list.** If you cannot find one, ask your manager, IT, privacy, or compliance team before pasting.
- ☐ **Use the work account when provided.** Personal accounts are usually outside your employer’s reviewed environment.
- ☐ **Minimize the data.** Remove names, record numbers, dates of birth, addresses, contact details, and anything not needed for the task.
- ☐ **Do not paste contracts, HR matters, incident reports, or legal advice** into an unapproved tool.
- ☐ **Keep a human reviewer** for anything consequential, public, or sent to another person.
- ☐ **Label the draft.** “AI-assisted draft, reviewed by [name]” is clearer than pretending every first draft was fully human.

For healthcare workers

- ☐ **Never enter protected health information (PHI)** — names, medical record numbers, birth dates, diagnoses, test results, images, schedules that reveal care — into a general-purpose AI tool unless your employer has explicitly approved that use.
- ☐ **Treat patient stories as private.** Changing a name is not automatically de-identification. A rare condition, small town, date, age, or job can identify someone.
- ☐ **Use non-identifiable educational questions.** Ask about a condition in general; do not paste a patient message, chart note, or image.
- ☐ **Verify clinical information** with current approved clinical resources and qualified colleagues. An AI is not a clinical authority.
- ☐ **Escalate pressure to use an unapproved tool.** Ask in writing and follow your organization’s reporting policy.

WATCH OUT

This is education, not compliance advice

HIPAA, state law, licensing rules, and your employer’s policies may all apply — and they can be stricter than this page. When in doubt, stop before the paste and ask the person whose job is privacy at your organization.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

If you overshared

Shame is not a recovery plan. Act quickly, stay specific, and fix what is fixable. Most of this is about limiting the damage and getting the right person involved early.

The practical sequence

01 **Name exactly what left your hands.** Was it text, a file, a screenshot, a voice note, or a link? Which account and tool? When? Write it down before memory gets fuzzy.

02 **Remove it from the current view.** Delete the message or file if the tool allows. Check trash and shared links too. You may also need to remove the content from a synced folder.

03 **Revoke access.** Disconnect the app, turn off the public link, and sign out of shared devices. Enable multi-factor authentication.

04 **Rotate exposed credentials from another trusted device.** Passwords need changing. API keys, access tokens, and recovery codes need revoking. Never paste a real secret into an AI chat to ask whether it is sensitive.

05 **Use the provider's privacy controls.** Opt out of training where offered, check the retention policy, and submit a deletion request through official support if needed. Do not assume instant removal.

06 **Tell the right human early.** For work, client, patient, or customer data, follow the incident policy and tell your manager or privacy officer. For financial data, contact the bank or card issuer. If identity theft is a risk, use official reporting channels.

07 **Keep a short record.** Date, data, tool, actions taken, people informed, and anything still open. A timeline is more useful than a spiral.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

My containment record

What was shared:

Where it went and when:

People informed / next check:

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **A mistake is not a character flaw**
>
> It is a data-handling event. Do not pour more sensitive details into a chat while asking how to fix the first leak — and do not quietly delete evidence your workplace is required to preserve. Get help.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

Your household privacy plan

Privacy is shared when the laptop is. A family plan does not need to be complicated; it needs a few agreed habits and a device that locks.

House rules worth agreeing on

- ☐ **Use separate profiles or accounts** on shared computers and tablets. One unlocked adult account is a group project nobody wants.
- ☐ **Ask before uploading someone else's data.** Photos, voices, messages, and health details belong to the person they describe.
- ☐ **Keep private chats off shared screens.** Use temporary chats for one-offs and log out of public or shared devices.
- ☐ **Talk about synthetic media.** Anyone can make a convincing fake image or voice. Verify urgent requests through a second channel.
- ☐ **Protect young users.** Use age-appropriate accounts and supervision; discuss what should never be shared, including school, location, and images of friends.
- ☐ **Help older relatives pause on "urgent" messages.** A callback to a known number is stronger than a frantic chat reply.

Our data map

WHERE WE USE AI	WHAT PRIVATE DETAIL MIGHT APPEAR	SAFER HABIT

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 03

Our three house rules

Rule 1

Rule 2

Rule 3

The quarterly reset

- ☐ Delete old chats with personal information.
- ☐ Check training and memory settings.
- ☐ Remove unused apps, extensions, and connectors.
- ☐ Rotate shared passwords and check MFA.
- ☐ Revisit this plan together.

> TRY THIS
>
> **Make the easy choice the safe choice**
>
> Keep the private laptop profile locked, put the approved work tool on the work profile, and keep a small “no personal details” note near the shared computer. Privacy gets better when it requires fewer decisions.

ONE LAST THING · 03

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Do the ten-minute account checkup, then put a quarterly privacy reset on your calendar. One small appointment is worth a dozen good intentions.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

Use AI like a useful first draft — not a final authority. Keep your judgment, check the facts, and protect private information.

More AI printables

01 AI Prompt Cheat Sheets

02 Beginner AI Glossary

04 AI for Job Search

05 AI for Budgeting

06 The 7-Day AI Learning Challenge

Free to use

Print these for yourself, your classroom, or a client. Please keep the credit and don't resell the files.

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.

PRACTICAL WORKBOOK

AI for Job Search

Less scrolling. More signal.

AI can help you organize the search, sharpen the words, and rehearse the conversation. It cannot know your worth, invent your evidence, or guarantee a job.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 A truthful, low-chaos workflow
02 Your evidence bank worksheet
03 Job-post decoding prompts
04 Resume, outreach, and interview pages
05 A seven-day sprint and scam check

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 04

Start before you open a chatbot

A job search gets easier when you separate the work into three lanes. AI is useful in all three — as long as the facts come from you and the final decision stays with a human.

Organize

Pick a target, collect job posts, inventory real evidence, and keep a tracker. This is where AI saves the most time.

Draft

Turn facts into a clearer resume bullet, application, or message. You edit until it sounds like a person you would hire.

Rehearse

Practice interview answers, find vague spots, and prepare questions. Feedback is a mirror, not a verdict.

The honesty rule

WATCH OUT

Never let AI invent your experience

No fake credentials, no invented metrics, no “confident” claims you cannot defend in an interview. AI should help you say true things more clearly. A polished lie is still a liability.

Your twenty-minute setup

- ☐ **Choose one or two target roles.** “Any job in healthcare” is not a target; “RN care coordinator” is.
- ☐ **Collect three current job posts.** Use official employer sites or reputable listings.
- ☐ **List five real wins.** Projects, problems you solved, people you helped, systems you improved. Numbers help only if they are true.
- ☐ **Open your current resume.** Keep one master version as your source of truth.
- ☐ **Remove sensitive details** from anything you plan to paste: government IDs, account numbers, patient or client information, and confidential employer material.
- ☐ **Set a timer.** Twenty minutes of setup is worth more than two hours of prompt roulette.

TRY THIS

A useful sentence to remember

“Use only the facts I give you. If evidence is missing, ask me for it instead of filling the gap.” Add this to almost every job-search prompt.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 04

Know what you're selling

Before the AI can tailor anything, it needs the truth about you. Fill this in with facts you could comfortably explain to a hiring manager. Keep notes; this page becomes your evidence bank.

My target

TARGET ROLE	WHY THIS WORK MATTERS TO ME	ONE THING I WANT TO LEARN NEXT

Evidence I can defend

Focus on what you did, the skill it shows, and the result or lesson. Team wins count — name your real part.

WHAT I DID	SKILL IT SHOWS	RESULT, PROOF, OR WHAT CHANGED

My through-line

In two or three sentences, connect where you have been to the role you want. Do not make it sound like a LinkedIn parable. Just tell the honest bridge.

GOOD TO KNOW

You are allowed to be a career changer

Your nursing judgment, classroom management, caregiving, military service, or years at a front desk are not "background." They are evidence of skills. The work is translating them accurately, not erasing them.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 04

Decode before you rewrite

A job post is a wish list written by a committee. Read it for the real work, the must-haves, and the gaps — before you let a tool rewrite your resume around it.

PROMPT RECIPE — DECODE THE JOB POST

Here is a job posting: [paste].

Summarize in plain English:
1. The actual daily work.
2. Requirements that seem truly essential versus nice-to-have.
3. Any signs of an unrealistic wish list.
4. Three good questions to ask an interviewer.

Use only the posting. Make it clear when you are inferring something.

PROMPT RECIPE — FIT CHECK, WITHOUT FLATTERY

Compare these two:

1. Job post: [paste]
2. My evidence bank: [paste]

Make a three-column table: requirement / evidence I already have / gap. Quote only my words. If the evidence is weak or missing, say so plainly. Do not invent experience, translate a gap into a strength, or call me a perfect fit.

Read the gap, don't hide it

- **Same skill, different words:** "Client communication" and "patient education" may be a real translation. Make the connection explicit and honest.
- **Partial experience:** Say what scope you actually handled. "Supported" and "led" are not interchangeable.
- **A true gap:** Name it, then make a plan. A short course, small project, volunteer task, informational conversation, or portfolio sample is stronger than a fictional bullet.
- **A wish-list mismatch:** If you meet most core requirements and the work excites you, applying may still be reasonable. A tool cannot decide your risk tolerance.

TRY THIS

Job descriptions are not grade sheets

Employers routinely ask for more than they will find. Use the post to aim your language, not to reject yourself on their behalf. Let the human with the budget make the first no.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 04

Tailor without stretching the truth

Good tailoring makes a real match easier to see. It does not create one. Use these prompts to find the clearest honest phrasing — then keep every fact in place.

PROMPT RECIPE — FIND THE HONEST KEYWORD MATCHES

Using only this job post and my resume, list the words and phrases the employer repeats. Show where each appears in my resume, if at all. Then suggest three places where a truthful rewrite could make a match clearer. Show before and after. Do not add skills, tools, dates, titles, or results.

PROMPT RECIPE — SHARPEN THESE RESUME BULLETS

Rewrite the three resume bullets below so each leads with the outcome, uses concrete verbs, and reflects the job's language where accurate.

Keep every fact. Do not inflate titles, team size, scope, or numbers. If a bullet lacks evidence, ask me for the missing detail instead of inventing it.

Bullets: [paste]

The sixty-second truth check

- ☐ **Explainability:** Could I explain every phrase in an interview without backpedaling?
- ☐ **Proof:** Can I point to where each number and result came from?
- ☐ **Continuity:** Did I preserve real dates, titles, tools, and team roles?
- ☐ **Fairness:** Would a former coworker recognize this as a fair description of my part?
- ☐ **Confidentiality:** Did I remove client names, proprietary details, patient information, and internal metrics I am not allowed to share?
- ☐ **Voice:** Does it still sound like me, or like a paint-by-numbers "results-driven professional"?

Keep one master resume

Your master resume can be long and detailed. It is your private source of truth: every role, project, number, tool, and short story. Tailored resumes are cut from it, not conjured from a chat window. When the AI asks for missing evidence, look it up rather than letting it guess.

GOOD TO KNOW

Keywords are not a personality

Matching the employer's language can help a human see your fit. Stuffing every phrase into white text or turning the page into a buzzword swamp does not. Write for the person who has to understand it, plus whatever legitimate application system is in the path.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 04

Write like a person

The best job messages are specific enough that the reader believes you looked. AI can help with structure and pace; you supply the real reason, the verified detail, and the warmth.

PROMPT RECIPE — THE COVER LETTER

Help me draft a 180–220 word cover letter for [role] at [organization].

Use only the facts I provide:
- Three relevant proof points: [paste]
- Why this work matters to me: [paste]
- One specific detail from the organization's public work or posting: [paste]

Structure: a specific opening, two short evidence paragraphs, and a warm close. Don't invent enthusiasm, achievements, or a personal connection. Match my voice: [plain / warm / formal].

PROMPT RECIPE — THE RECRUITER MESSAGE

Write a 75-word email to [name] about [role]. Mention one verified detail about the team's work, one sentence on my relevant evidence, and a low-pressure ask. No empty flattery, no invented connection, and no "I hope this email finds you well."

PROMPT RECIPE — THE FOLLOW-UP

Draft a follow-up [number] days after my [interview / application] on [date]. Reference one concrete point from our conversation: [detail]. Keep it under 90 words, warm and confident. Don't invent a deadline or pressure them for a decision.

Before you send

- ☐ Fill every bracket. A leftover `[organization]` is a tiny confession.
- ☐ Verify the organization detail against an official source.
- ☐ Check names, titles, and spelling.
- ☐ Remove claims you could not defend or prove.
- ☐ Read it aloud. If it sounds like a brochure, cut.
- ☐ Add one sentence only you could write.

WATCH OUT

Volume is not a strategy

AI makes it easy to send a hundred forgettable applications. The reader can usually tell. A smaller number of specific, honest applications is kinder to your time and your reputation. Do not automate a process that relies on trust.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 04

Interview practice that actually helps

A mock interview is useful when it pushes for specifics. A generic bot that says “great answer!” is a mirror with no reflection. These prompts ask for evidence, structure, and one clear next step.

Build two stories you can reuse

Use real situations. A story about a small, ordinary task often reveals more than a grand one you barely remember.

STORY	SITUATION AND TASK	ACTION I TOOK	RESULT OR LESSON

PROMPT RECIPE — A DEMANDING MOCK INTERVIEW

Act as a respectful hiring manager for [role] at [industry or type of organization]. Ask me one behavioral question at a time. Wait for my answer, then rate it 1–5 on specificity, structure, and relevance. Ask one follow-up that would expose missing evidence. After five questions, name two strong themes in my answers and two answers I should rebuild. Do not invent facts for me.

PROMPT RECIPE — FIND THE VAGUE PARTS

For my answer below, identify where I was vague, where I took credit for team work, and what result I left unstated. Ask me one question per gap. Then help me rewrite only with details I confirm.

My answer: [paste]

Questions worth having in your head

“Tell me about a conflict.” “Tell me about a failure.” “Tell me about a time you influenced without authority.” “How do you prioritize?” “Why this role, and why now?”

GOOD TO KNOW

The AI interviewer is not the labor market

It does not know the company’s culture, the interviewer’s priorities, or whether the job is still funded. Use it to make your examples sharper and your thinking clearer. Verify salary, schedule, and role expectations with the employer and current public sources.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 04

Your seven-day search sprint

Seven small moves, not seven perfect days. Aim for twenty to thirty minutes, take the low-energy option when you need it, and count honest progress rather than applications sprayed into the void.

The week

- ☐ **Day 1 — Choose a direction.** Pick one or two target roles and fill in your evidence bank.
- ☐ **Day 2 — Read the market.** Decode three postings. Circle repeated skills; note the gaps that show up more than once.
- ☐ **Day 3 — Refresh the source.** Update your master resume with missing facts and clean up one outdated section.
- ☐ **Day 4 — Make one strong application.** Tailor a resume, draft the message, and have a human or a careful AI review for truth.
- ☐ **Day 5 — Rehearse.** Build two STAR stories and run five mock questions.
- ☐ **Day 6 — Verify and connect.** Research two organizations through official sources; send one specific question or follow-up.
- ☐ **Day 7 — Review.** Update the tracker, capture one lesson, and choose next week's three priorities. Rest is part of the plan.

Application tracker

DATE	ORGANIZATION AND ROLE	CONTACT OR SOURCE	STATUS	NEXT STEP AND DATE

TRY THIS

The low-energy version

Day 1: open the evidence bank and write one win. Day 3: update one bullet. Day 5: practice one answer. A job search is not a personality test. Small, repeatable contact with the work beats waiting until you feel impressive.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 04

Spot the scam, protect your search

AI can help you write and rehearse. It cannot tell you whether an employer is real. Use it to notice patterns, then verify through official sources and a phone call.

Red flags that deserve a stop

- ☐ You must pay for training, equipment, a background check, or “priority placement.”
- ☐ They send a check and ask you to buy supplies or send part of the money back.
- ☐ They request crypto, gift cards, wire transfers, or unusual bank access.
- ☐ They ask for a Social Security number, bank details, or ID images before a written offer from a verified employer.
- ☐ The “interview” is only text chat, with no camera, phone, or person attached to the organization.
- ☐ The offer is urgent, secret, or too good to be true.
- ☐ The recruiter uses a free email domain while claiming to represent a large organization.
- ☐ Links lead to a lookalike domain rather than the official careers page.
- ☐ They send you software to install or ask for remote access to your computer.
- ☐ They cannot answer basic questions about the role, manager, pay structure, or location.

Verify before you reply

01 **Open the employer’s official site yourself.** Do not trust the link in the message; use a search result or a known address.

02 **Find the job on the official careers page.** Call the published number and ask for the recruiter or HR team by name.

03 **Get it in writing.** Confirm the legal employer, pay structure, schedule, location, and onboarding process.

04 **Share sensitive details only at the right stage.** Identity and payroll information belongs in a verified, secure onboarding process — never in a chat or awkward email thread.

PROMPT RECIPE — CHECK THIS CONTACT FOR RED FLAGS

Help me assess this job contact for warning signs. I’ll paste the message with my personal details removed. Identify red flags and anything that seems legitimate, but do not certify that the employer is real. Give me three verification steps using official sources.

Message: [paste]

WATCH OUT

“The AI said it was fine”

That is not verification. A language model can describe scam patterns, but it cannot independently confirm that a company, recruiter, or offer exists. Check official contact channels and never send money or credentials to unlock a job.

ONE LAST THING · 04

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Fill in your target role and three proof points before you prompt anything. The AI can help you shape true evidence; it cannot supply it for you.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

Use AI like a useful first draft — not a final authority. Keep your judgment, check the facts, and protect private information.

More AI printables

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.

PRACTICAL WORKBOOK

AI for Budgeting

A gentler relationship with money math.

A low-shame workbook for making the invisible visible: your bills, your patterns, your priorities, and the next small step.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 Ground rules and privacy first
02 A one-page money snapshot
03 Bills, subscriptions, and leaks
04 Plain-English planning prompts
05 Debt, savings, and tight months

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

Start with a money map

A budget is not a moral report card. It is a plan for directing money before the month directs it for you. You do not need a perfect spreadsheet to begin; you need a rough picture and a little honesty.

Rough is enough

Round to the nearest dollar or ten. Use one normal-ish month. Chasing exact cents can become a magnificent way to avoid the actual plan.

AI is not your advisor

It can organize, explain, and calculate. It does not know your whole life, current local programs, or your real risk tolerance. Verify important numbers and use a qualified human for advice.

Keep access out

Never give a chatbot your bank login, card number, routing number, government ID, or security answers. Use totals and categories instead.

WATCH OUT

This is education, not financial advice

Tax, investment, debt, benefits, and legal decisions depend on facts an AI cannot verify. For those, use a qualified professional, a nonprofit credit counselor, or an official government source. For cash-flow organization, a simple plan and a careful calculator can still help.

What AI can and cannot do here

- **Can help:** group categories, draft a meal plan around a number, explain a confusing fee in plain English, build a bill checklist, compare debt payoff arithmetic, or practice a call with a service provider.
- **Cannot do:** guarantee an outcome, know today's rates and rules, replace emergency help, choose investments, prepare your taxes, negotiate legally binding terms, or make high-stakes decisions for you.
- **Will sometimes do:** get arithmetic wrong. Check any number that changes a decision on a real calculator or spreadsheet.

TRY THIS

The first useful step is noticing

You are not behind because you need to look. A money map is information, not a verdict. Start with what is true this month, then choose one change that fits your actual energy.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

Your money snapshot

Use one normal month — not the most expensive holiday season and not your best week. Round generously. If a number is unknown, write `?` and come back to it. Keep account numbers and identifying details out of anything you paste into AI.

This month's rough picture

CATEGORY	AMOUNT	NOTES
Income after tax		
Housing (rent or mortgage, utilities, insurance)		
Food (groceries and meals)		
Transportation (fuel, transit, car costs)		
Health (insurance, prescriptions, appointments)		
Care (children, elders, pets)		
Phone and internet		
Debt minimum payments		
Other essentials (laundry, supplies, fees)		
Flexible spending (fun, dining, hobbies)		
Savings or buffer transfer		
Total spending		
What is left (income minus spending)		

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

What this page does not mean

A negative number is not a character flaw; it is a math fact that needs a response. An unspent amount is not automatically “free” — irregular costs like car repairs, school supplies, and annual renewals need a home too.

What I want this plan to protect

GOOD TO KNOW

Use categories, not confessions

The AI does not need to know the name of the restaurant, the clinic, or the person you paid. “Food: $310” is usually more useful than a transaction-level story. If you use an AI tool for categorization, redact names, account references, and dates first.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

Bills, subscriptions, and the small leaks

Automatic payments are convenient partly because they stop asking for attention. This page asks for it back. You are looking for surprises, not punishing yourself for having a life.

The bill calendar

DUE	BILL	AMOUNT	AUTOPAY?	PAID

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

The subscription audit

SERVICE	MONTHLY COST	LAST USED	KEEP, PAUSE, OR CANCEL?

Look in three places: your statement or payment history, your app store subscriptions, and annual renewal emails. A yearly charge can be easy to dismiss because it arrives all at once. Divide it by twelve before deciding it is “only a little.”

PROMPT RECIPE — SORT THE SUBSCRIPTIONS WITHOUT THE SHAME

Here is an anonymized list of subscriptions and rounded costs: [paste]. Rank them by monthly impact, flag anything that looks like an annual renewal, and give me neutral questions to ask before I keep each one. Don’t tell me to cancel essentials or make assumptions about what I need.

One small action

- ☐ Cancel or pause one thing you do not use.
- ☐ Put one annual renewal on the calendar.
- ☐ Check one autopay amount against the current bill.
- ☐ Ask a provider about a lower-cost plan or hardship option, if needed.

TRY THIS

Annual does not mean invisible

A $60 yearly renewal feels different from $5 a month, but it is the same money leaving. Notice the full amount, then decide on purpose.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

Categorize without oversharing

AI can be a useful clerk. It should not become the bank. Start with totals you prepared, then ask it to organize patterns — not to collect your identity.

Make a safe summary first

01 **Total at the source.** Use your own spreadsheet, paper, or bank's budgeting view to get category totals.

02 **Remove names.** Replace merchants, employers, clinics, and people with generic labels.

03 **Round the amounts.** The plan needs the shape, not the receipt level.

04 **Strip identifiers.** No account numbers, card numbers, addresses, SSNs, dates of birth, or security answers.

PROMPT RECIPE — GROUP THE TOTALS, NOT THE TRANSACTIONS

I'm organizing a monthly budget, not asking for financial advice. Here are my rounded category totals: [paste categories and amounts]. Help me group them into needs, flexible spending, and savings or debt payments. Point out clusters I may want to look at. Ask a question if a category is ambiguous, and do not guess missing amounts.

PROMPT RECIPE — ASK BETTER QUESTIONS ABOUT THE CHANGE

Here are my anonymous category totals for this month and last month: [paste]. Give me five neutral questions I should ask myself about the changes. Do not label spending as good or bad or assume you know why it changed. Separate the facts from possible explanations.

The short "keep out" list

FINE TO SHARE	KEEP OUT
Rounded category totals	Bank logins and passwords
A made-up goal like "a $1,000 buffer"	Full account, card, or routing numbers
Your own debt labels like "Card A"	SSN, tax ID, or security answers
Current minimum payments	Full transaction exports with names and addresses

WATCH OUT

Verify the arithmetic

Language models can produce a confident total that is simply wrong. Use a spreadsheet or calculator for anything that changes a real decision. AI can explain the math; you still get to check it.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

Build a plan you can live with

A plan that only works during your most organized week is not a plan. It is a hope with a spreadsheet. Choose one approach, keep it simple, and leave room for real life.

Four starting points

- **Percent-based:** Divide take-home pay into rough shares for needs, flexible spending, and savings or debt. The well-known 50/30/20 split is a guideline, not a law; housing costs and income can make it unrealistic.
- **Zero-based:** Assign every dollar a job until income minus planned spending equals zero. Precise and useful if you like detail; maintenance-heavy if you do not.
- **Pay yourself first:** Move a savings or debt payment at payday, then plan the rest. Only works if essentials already fit in what remains.
- **Minimum plan:** Cover essentials, one small buffer, and one goal. This is the version to use when energy or income is low.

PROMPT RECIPE — DRAFT A PLAN FROM MY ACTUAL TOTALS

Help me draft a monthly spending plan from these rounded totals: [paste income and categories].

My non-negotiables are: [housing, food, medication, transport, care].
My priorities are: [one or two things I want to protect].
Include a small buffer and label every assumption. Keep planned spending at or below income. If the numbers don’t work, say so plainly and show which categories create the pressure. Don’t recommend investments, tax moves, loans, or debt products.

My draft plan

CATEGORY	CURRENT	PROPOSED	CHANGE

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

Make it survivable

- ☐ Put irregular costs — car repairs, school supplies, annual bills — in a monthly set-aside.
- ☐ Include some joy. A plan with no room for a $5 pleasure is more likely to break.
- ☐ Automate one transfer or one bill; do not engineer twenty fragile steps.
- ☐ Schedule a ten-minute review. A budget is a draft, not a contract.

GOOD TO KNOW

If essentials exceed income

Organization cannot squeeze money out of an income that does not cover basic needs. Prioritize housing, food, medication, utilities, and essential transport. Look for official benefits, community assistance, and nonprofit credit counseling. Be wary of anyone who requires an upfront fee for “guaranteed” help.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

Debt and savings, one line at a time

You do not need to solve everything today. Start with an honest list, understand the two common payoff methods, and give savings a small, visible target. This is organization — not a recommendation to take on debt products or investments.

The clean list

Use labels if you plan to ask AI for math. You do not need to paste creditor names or account numbers.

LABEL	BALANCE	INTEREST RATE	MINIMUM PAYMENT	DUE DATE
Card A				
Loan B				
Card C				
Other				

Two common approaches

Snowball: Pay minimums everywhere, then put extra money toward the smallest balance. It often builds momentum.

Avalanche: Pay minimums everywhere, then put extra money toward the highest interest rate. It usually saves more interest if rates and balances stay as you entered them.

Both depend on terms, fees, and your actual rates. Check each statement and ask the lender when a number is unclear. Never stop paying a required minimum to chase a cleaner spreadsheet.

PROMPT RECIPE — COMPARE THE MATH, NOT THE HYPE

I owe the following, anonymized: [label, balance, interest rate, minimum payment]. I can add [extra amount] per month. Compare avalanche and snowball payoff order and show your arithmetic and assumptions. Do not recommend loans, investments, settlement companies, or a specific product. I will verify every number with my statements.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

A savings target you can see

Use a simple division: **goal amount ÷ months = monthly set-aside.** If a month is tight, decide on the fallback before it happens. A smaller automatic transfer that survives is often more useful than a heroic number that does not.

PROMPT RECIPE — MAKE THE SAVINGS GOAL CONCRETE

Help me break a savings goal into monthly and per-paycheck amounts. Goal: [amount and purpose]. Target date: [date]. Current savings: [amount]. My income is [steady or irregular]. Show the math, include a smaller fallback version, and list what I need to verify.

TRY THIS

Do not optimize on a broken foundation

A buffer for food and a working car may matter more than the mathematically perfect debt order. Ask a nonprofit credit counselor for help if minimum payments are crowding out essentials.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

The tight month

Some months, the plan is not optimization. The plan is protection. If you are choosing between essentials right now, skip the color-coded spreadsheet and start with the next right step.

Minimum mode

- ☐ **Cover the essentials first:** housing, food, medication, utilities, essential transport, and required minimum payments.
- ☐ **Contact one bill provider before a payment is missed.** Ask about hardship plans, extensions, or lower-cost options. Get the agreement in writing.
- ☐ **Use what you have.** Plan a few simple meals around food already at home.
- ☐ **Pause one nonessential expense** rather than trying to cancel everything at once.
- ☐ **Avoid payday loans, crypto "fixes," and anyone who asks for an upfront fee** for guaranteed help. If an offer creates more pressure, walk away and ask a trusted human.
- ☐ **Ask for official help.** In the US, 211 connects callers to community services; state benefits portals and nonprofit credit counselors may also help. Confirm fees and credentials.

PROMPT RECIPE — PLAN THE NEXT TWO WEEKS, HONESTLY

The next two weeks are tight. Here are my fixed obligations and the money available: [rounded totals, no account details]. Help me order essential payments and plan three low-cost meals from what I have. Show where the plan is unrealistic. Do not suggest borrowing, investing, skipping essential medical care, or using a high-cost product. End with one realistic phone call or official resource I should check.

The low-energy versions

Five minutes

List the next bill due. Pause one subscription. Choose one simple meal.

Fifteen minutes

Write your five biggest spending categories. Check one autopay. Put a reminder for the next due date.

Thirty minutes

Fill in the money snapshot. Choose one protection for the next thirty days: a bill call, a food plan, or a small buffer.

GOOD TO KNOW

You do not have to explain your dignity

Asking a utility, lender, clinic, or benefits office for help is not failure. Many staff have a standard hardship process. Ask what options exist, write down the answer, and keep your own record. You are allowed to need the system to work.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

The thirty-day gentle reset

This is not a get-rich month. It is a month of noticing, one deliberate change, and a plan you can repeat without dread. Mark what you actually did; leave the rest for later.

Four small weeks

- [ ] **Week 1 — Look.** Fill in the money snapshot and list recurring bills. No changes required.
- [ ] **Week 2 — Trim one thing.** Pause one unused subscription, plan three meals, or set one bill reminder.
- [ ] **Week 3 — Protect one thing.** Move a small amount to a buffer, check one debt statement, or contact one provider about a better option.
- [ ] **Week 4 — Keep one habit.** Review what happened, choose one repeatable action, and schedule the next monthly check-in.

The monthly check-in

PROMPT RECIPE — REVIEW WITHOUT THE SHAME SPIRAL

Here are last month's and this month's rounded category totals: [paste]. Point out the changes without calling spending good or bad. Ask me one question about each meaningful shift. Then suggest one small experiment for next month that does not require me to become a different person. Do not give investment, tax, or debt-product advice.

PROMPT RECIPE — THE FIVE-MINUTE CHECK-IN

I have five minutes. Ask me five short questions that help me notice what happened with money this month. Keep each question under twenty words. End with one small next action.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 05

What I want to remember

When a human is the better tool

Talk with a qualified benefits counselor, nonprofit credit counselor, or licensed professional if:

- essentials are consistently not covered,
- minimum payments are crowding out food, housing, medication, or care,
- you are facing legal action or eviction,
- you cannot tell whether a debt or benefit offer is legitimate,
- or money stress is affecting your sleep, safety, or mental health.

WATCH OUT

No AI bravado

A confident chatbot is not a safety net. If a decision affects your housing, health, immigration status, taxes, or legal rights, slow down and use a qualified human source. A printable checklist is a starting point, not a rescue plan.

ONE LAST THING · 05

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Gather last month's rounded category totals — never your account numbers — and fill in the money snapshot. Clarity first; changes later.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

Use AI like a useful first draft — not a final authority. Keep your judgment, check the facts, and protect private information.

More AI printables

01 AI Prompt Cheat Sheets

02 Beginner AI Glossary

03 AI Privacy Checklist

04 AI for Job Search

06 The 7-Day AI Learning Challenge

Free to use

Print these for yourself, your classroom, or a client. Please keep the credit and don't resell the files.

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.

GUIDED CHALLENGE

The 7-Day AI Learning Challenge

Fifteen minutes a day. One calmer relationship with AI.

No streaks to protect, no expensive tools required, and no prize for becoming an "AI person" by Friday. Just one useful practice at a time.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 A simple setup and weekly tracker
02 Seven 15-minute daily practices
03 Prompts and privacy reminders
04 Space to reflect after each day
05 A realistic plan for what comes next

PLAIN *ENGLISH* ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 06

How this week works

This is a learning challenge for people with a life. Fifteen minutes can count. Missing a day can count too. The point is to build a little firsthand experience, not to perform enthusiasm for a technology.

What you need

- One AI assistant you can access. Many offer free tiers; you do not need to pay for this challenge.
- A notes app or paper for saved prompts and observations.
- A timer and roughly fifteen minutes a day.
- A healthy amount of skepticism.
- Under 18? Ask a parent or guardian and use the account or supervision they approve.

Three ground rules

- **Pick one tool for the week.** Switching tools every day turns practice into browsing. You can compare tools later.
- **Keep private data out.** Use invented details for exercises. No government IDs, bank details, medical records, patient information, other people's messages, or confidential work material.
- **Follow the rules where you learn or work.** A school, employer, or professional body may say no to AI use even when the tool says yes. Those rules come first.

The week at a glance

DAY	PRACTICE	DONE
1	Meet the machine	☐
2	Upgrade one prompt	☐
3	Learn something real	☐
4	Make something useful	☐
5	Check before you trust	☐
6	Build a tiny workflow	☐
7	Teach it back	☐

TRY THIS

The only streak that matters

If you miss a day, open the next page and continue. No reset, no confession, no catching up by doing three days at once. The challenge is a container, not a deadline.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 06

Day 1: Meet the machine

Today's aim: Build a realistic first impression. Learn what this tool does well, where it gets slippery, and how it wants to be talked to. Fifteen minutes, no perfect prompt required.

Your 15 minutes

01 **Minute 1–2: Start clean.** Open a new chat. Take a breath. There is no penalty for asking a basic question.

02 **Minute 3–10: Try three questions.** Ask about something you know well, something that needs a current fact, and something that requires a small plan.

03 **Minute 11–15: Look for the seams.** Notice what was generic, confidently vague, or flat-out wrong. Write down one limitation.

PROMPT RECIPE — START WITH A TOUR

I'm new to AI. Ask me three questions about what I want help with, then give me one small practice task based on my answers. Keep the language plain. Tell me two things you are not reliable for.

WATCH OUT

It is predicting, not knowing

A language model produces likely language based on patterns. It does not automatically look up a fact, know your situation, or understand consequences. A fluent answer is not evidence.

You're done when

- [ ] You have tried three different kinds of question.
- [ ] You can finish this sentence: "This tool is useful for _____, but I need to check _____."
- [ ] You noticed one moment where it was not a reliable authority.

One thing that surprised me:

One limit I noticed:

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 06

Day 2: Upgrade one prompt

Today's aim: Feel the difference between a vague wish and a useful request. This is the single skill that makes everything else in the week easier.

Your 15 minutes

01 **Minute 1–3: Ask a lazy version.** Try "Help me plan my week." Notice what comes back.

02 **Minute 4–10: Add what matters.** Give the goal, real constraints, a format, and one boundary.

03 **Minute 11–15: Compare.** Put the two answers side by side. Write down one specific difference.

PROMPT RECIPE — BEFORE: VAGUE

Help me plan my week.

PROMPT RECIPE — AFTER: USEFUL

Help me plan the next five weekdays around these real tasks: [paste 4–6 tasks]. I have about [hours available] and want to protect time for [priority]. Give me a simple table with day, focus, and a 20-minute minimum version. Don't fill every hour;
leave white space. Ask me one question if the plan depends on
something missing.

You're done when

- [ ] You have a before-and-after pair.
- [ ] You can name the details that changed the answer.
- [ ] You have added one prompt to your notes.

The difference I noticed:

TRY THIS

Specific, not exhaustive

A useful prompt is not a five-page autobiography. It gives the model the details that change the result: the goal, the constraints, the audience, the format, and what not to do.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 06

Day 3: Learn something real

Today's aim: Use AI as a tutor, not an answer machine. Pick something you have been meaning to understand — a concept, a process, a piece of software, a chapter of a book.

Your 15 minutes

01 **Minute 1–2: Pick a topic and say what you already know.** A small useful topic beats a giant vague one.

02 **Minute 3–10: Learn through questions.** Ask the AI to quiz you and wait for your answers.

03 **Minute 11–15: Explain it back without looking.** Then ask for one correction and one next gap.

Need a topic? Try how a bill becomes law, how compound interest works, what an API is, how local AI runs on a computer, or how to read a nutrition label. Choose something you actually want to know.

PROMPT RECIPE — BE MY PATIENT TUTOR

Be my plain-English tutor for [topic]. I know [your starting point]. Ask me one question at a time and wait for my answer. Start with a concrete example, not a definition. After five questions, ask me to explain the idea back. Then point out one accurate part and one gap. Don't praise me unless there is something specific to praise.

You're done when

- ☐ You have written a three-sentence explanation in your own words.
- ☐ You can name one thing that still feels fuzzy.
- ☐ You have not used AI as a substitute for a teacher, clinician, or required source.

My three-sentence explanation:

Still fuzzy:

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 06

Day 4: Make something useful

Today's aim: Create one modest, real thing you would actually use. Not a demo. Not a masterpiece. A draft that saves you a little time or starts a stuck task.

Your 15 minutes

01 **Minute 1–3: Choose a small real task.** An email you have been avoiding, a packing list, a meal plan, a project outline, a plain-language summary of public information, a story idea, a chore schedule.

02 **Minute 4–10: Make the first draft.** Give the AI your facts, audience, and format.

03 **Minute 11–15: Edit by hand.** Change anything that does not sound like you, check the details, and remove what does not belong.

PROMPT RECIPE — MAKE A USEFUL FIRST DRAFT

Help me create [specific thing] for [audience]. The result needs to [outcome].

Here are the facts: [paste non-sensitive notes].
Use this format: [email / checklist / table / outline].
Keep it [plain, warm, direct]. Avoid [thing you don't want].
After the draft, list three places I should check before using it.

WATCH OUT

Follow the rules of the room

For school or work, use AI only when allowed. If disclosure is required, disclose. Do not let a draft take credit for work, judgment, or facts that are not yours.

You're done when

- [ ] You have a usable draft, not just a chat transcript.
- [ ] You changed at least three things by hand.
- [ ] You checked anything factual that matters.

What I made:

What I changed and why:

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 06

Day 5: Check before you trust

Today's aim: Practice the habit that separates useful assistance from quiet trouble. Check one claim, then do one privacy drill.

Your 15 minutes

01 **Minute 1–4: Pick a claim** from Day 3 or Day 4 — a date, number, rule, quotation, or "fact."

02 **Minute 5–10: Ask how it could be verified.** Then verify at least one claim with a primary or official source. If the tool gives links, open them.

03 **Minute 11–15: Practice redaction.** Rewrite one sentence or task so it contains no identifying details. If you cannot remove the detail safely, do not use AI for that task.

PROMPT RECIPE — SEPARATE FACT FROM FILLER

Fact-check this draft: [paste].

Separate verifiable facts from opinions, ideas, and style. For each fact, say what primary or official source could verify it. Mark anything you cannot support as "needs checking." Do not invent links, statistics, quotations, titles, or dates.

Your privacy drill

Turn real-ish details into placeholders before they go into a prompt.

TOO SPECIFIC	BETTER
A person's name and address	"A family member," "my town"
A bank, card, or account detail	"Card A," "a household bill"
A patient, client, or student detail	Remove it; ask a general question
A confidential project name	"An internal project"

You're done when

- ☐ You verified one claim outside the chat.
- ☐ You found zero invented citations to rely on.
- ☐ You practiced one redaction.
- ☐ You know one question you should ask a human instead.

The claim and what I found:

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 06

Day 6: Build a tiny workflow

Today's aim: Make one recurring task easier without giving up human review. A saved prompt in your notes is a perfectly respectable workflow.

Your 15 minutes

01 **Minute 1–3: Choose a small recurring task.** Weekly meal planning, meeting prep, a first-pass proofread, a study quiz, a project check-in, or turning notes into a clean outline.

02 **Minute 4–10: Write and test a reusable prompt.** Replace one-time details with clearly marked blanks.

03 **Minute 11–15: Add a human check.** Decide what you will always verify before using the output.

PROMPT RECIPE — TURN THIS INTO A REUSABLE PROMPT

Help me turn this recurring task into a reusable prompt: [describe the task]. Ask me up to three questions about the output, constraints, and common mistakes. Then write a fill-in-the-blank prompt I can save. Keep it under 150 words.

My tiny workflow

The task I do repeatedly:

My saved prompt:

My human check:

WATCH OUT

Leave the dangerous parts manual

Do not fully automate decisions involving money, medication, employment, legal matters, housing, other people's data, or anything irreversible. A workflow can prepare information; a human should approve the consequential step.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 06

Day 7: Teach it back

Today's aim: Turn a week of small experiences into understanding you can keep. Teaching is the test. If you can explain it plainly, you are less likely to be dazzled by it.

Your 15 minutes

01 **Minute 1–5: Explain the basics to someone** — a friend, a family member, or an empty page. What is AI good at? What is it not reliable for? What is one rule you will keep?

02 **Minute 6–10: Make a mini capstone.** Use AI for one small real task in three steps: define it, draft it, verify it. Save the result and your edits.

03 **Minute 11–15: Write your own policy.** Three sentences. Not a corporate manifesto. Just how you want to use this tool.

PROMPT RECIPE — HELP ME TEACH IT BACK

Interview me like a patient teacher. Ask me five questions about what I learned regarding [topic or this week's practice]. Then give me a short report card: one thing I explained well, one gap, and one next thing to learn. Be kind and specific; don't flatter me.

My personal AI rules

1. I will use AI for…

---

2. I will not put…

---

3. I will always check…

You're done when

- ☐ You have explained the basics out loud.
- ☐ You made one small thing and edited it.
- ☐ You wrote three rules you can actually follow.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 06

After the week

You did not become an AI expert in seven days. Good. Expertise is not the goal. A working sense of what the tool is for, where it fails, and when to stop is far more useful than memorizing features.

A quick look back

My favorite use this week:

The biggest limitation I noticed:

The habit I want to keep:

A fifteen-minute weekly practice

Pick one recurring appointment with yourself. Each week, do one small cycle:

- ☐ Learn one new thing.
- ☐ Make or improve one useful draft.
- ☐ Check one important claim.
- ☐ Save one prompt or lesson in your notes.

That is enough. You do not need to keep up with every release, app, or argument. The useful question is not “What can AI do now?” It is “What is a good use of AI in my actual life this week?”

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 06

Where to go next

- Revisit the challenge with a different real task.
- Read the **Beginner AI Glossary** when a word gets in the way.
- Use the **AI Privacy Checklist** before you connect a new tool or paste something personal.
- Try the **AI Prompt Cheat Sheets** when you want a better first draft.
- If you are curious about running a model on your own device, look for a local-AI guide and check your computer's memory and privacy setup first.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **This is not a certificate**
>
> No credential, guarantee, or professional qualification comes with this page. It is a record of practice. Keep the prompt, the rule, and the small habit that earned its place.

ONE LAST THING · 06

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Set a 15-minute appointment with yourself tomorrow and return to Day 1. You do not need momentum; you need a small, repeatable beginning.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

Use AI like a useful first draft — not a final authority. Keep your judgment, check the facts, and protect private information.

More AI printables

01 AI Prompt Cheat Sheets

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03 AI Privacy Checklist

04 AI for Job Search

05 AI for Budgeting

Free to use

Print these for yourself, your classroom, or a client. Please keep the credit and don't resell the files.

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.

LOW-ENERGY PLANNER

The Low-Energy Weekly Reset

A weekly plan that assumes you are a person.

This is not a productivity contest. It is a small weekly appointment for finding the next useful thing and letting the rest wait.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 A three-question capacity check-in
02 A one-page reset and weekly map
03 A 20-minute reset ritual
04 Energy-aware planning and daily minimums
05 A no-shame restart plan

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

Start with the week you actually have

Most planners ask you to invent a perfect week on Sunday and then punish you for being human by Wednesday. This one starts somewhere else: with the time, energy, and support you actually have.

ADHD can make planning feel like a trap. You make a beautiful list, lose interest in it, forget it exists, then find it three weeks later and feel bad. The problem is usually not effort. It is that the plan was built for a brain and a week that do not exist.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **The only rule**
>
> A plan is a guess, not a promise. If the guess is wrong, change the plan. Do not turn the plan into evidence against yourself.

Three questions before any list

01 **What is fixed?** Appointments, shifts, school runs, medication routines, bill due dates, and anything another person is counting on.

02 **What is already heavy?** Sleep, pain, caregiving, a difficult project, a social event, a commute. Name it so the plan can carry it.

03 **What would make this week 5% easier?** Not 100% better. Five percent. One ride, one prepared meal, one postponed decision, one honest no.

The week is not a test

You are allowed to plan for a low-capacity version of yourself. In fact, that is the useful version. If the week goes better than expected, you can add something. If it goes worse, you already have a floor to stand on.

Minimum

The smallest version that keeps the important things from becoming urgent. A bill paid. A prescription requested. A reply sent.

Steady

What you can usually do when nothing is on fire. A little meal planning, a load of laundry, a clear desk.

Stretch

The thing you would love to do if the stars align. Exercise, a project, a social plan. Optional by design.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

Keep the plan where your eyes already go

A planner only works if you encounter it. Put this week's page on the fridge, beside your bed, inside your work bag, or as a photo on your phone's home screen. "Out of sight, out of mind" is not a character flaw; it is a design brief.

What to ignore for now

- Colour-coding every area of life.
- A complicated app you have to maintain.
- A five-year vision board.
- Anyone else's morning routine.
- Catching up on everything the last plan missed.

Where it will live this week

FIRST CHOICE	BACK-UP PLACE	WHEN I WILL LOOK AT IT

The two-second reminder

Something I will see at the right moment — a sticky note, a phone wallpaper, an alarm label:

This page is enough. Turn over when you are ready.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

The one-page reset

Give this ten minutes. If ten is too much, do only the three boxes in the top row. You can leave the rest blank without failing the page.

1. The week in front of me

WHAT IS FIXED?	WHAT IS ALREADY HEAVY?	WHAT WOULD MAKE IT 5% EASIER?

2. Three outcomes, not thirty tasks

An outcome is a finished shape, not a guilt list. “Rent paid” beats “deal with money stuff.” “Clean clothes in drawers” beats “do laundry.”

MY THREE OUTCOMES THIS WEEK	WHAT IS THE SMALLEST FIRST STEP?	WHEN MIGHT IT FIT?
1.		
2.		
3.		

3. The one thing I will ignore on purpose

Permission is a planning tool. Choose something that can wait without serious harm.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

4. Where I need help

Name the kind of help, not just “everything.” “Could you pick up milk?” is easier to answer than “Can you help more?”

WHAT I NEED	WHO COULD HELP?	MY ASK, IN ONE SENTENCE

A menu of asks

Practical

A lift, a meal, a grocery run, watching the kids for an hour, helping move something heavy.

Paperwork

Sitting with me while I make a call, reading a letter together, helping me find the right number.

Company

Being in the room, body doubling on a task, checking in at an agreed time, listening without fixing.

5. Already done

Before you make the week feel impossible, write down one thing that is already handled. You got here. That counts.

TRY THIS

If you only do one thing

Put the three outcomes where you will see them tomorrow. A plan in a notebook you never open is a wish with a cover.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

A 20-minute reset ritual

This is not a full cleaning day. It is a short transition between the week you just finished and the one that is about to start. Use a timer, choose a stopping point, and leave the rest.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **Set the timer first**
>
> Twenty minutes means twenty minutes. When it rings, stop even if you are "on a roll." The goal is to make the reset repeatable, not to finish the whole house.

Before the timer

- ☐ One pen and one piece of paper.
- ☐ Your calendar in front of you.
- ☐ A bin bag or recycling bag within reach.
- ☐ The kit: this printable, the one-page reset, and a glass of water.
- ☐ A timer you can hear.

Minute-by-minute

Minutes 0–5 · Empty your head

Write every open loop on scrap paper. Appointments, worry, "I should," half-finished tasks, that thing you keep forgetting. Do not organise yet. Just get it out of the brain and onto the page.

Minutes 5–10 · Match the facts

Check the calendar and your messages. Add only the fixed things. Circle the three outcomes that still matter after seeing the real week.

Minutes 10–15 · Clear one surface

Choose one: kitchen counter, bedside table, entryway, desk. Put trash in the bag. Put items that belong elsewhere in one basket. Do not start a room-by-room overhaul.

Minutes 15–20 · Set the launch pad

Put the reset page where you will see it. Set out one thing for tomorrow. Choose a loose end you are allowed to leave. Then stop.

The stop rule

If the timer ends while you are mid-task, write the next physical action and leave it. "Put the receipts in the blue folder" is a better note than "sort paperwork." A next action is easier to restart than a vague intention.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

Your reset notes

Use this page during or after the reset. It does not need to be tidy. Write the thing you would otherwise keep carrying in your head.

What I noticed

What I want to carry forward

What can wait

What the ritual is not

It is not a test of whether you are “organised enough.” It is a repeated chance to lower the noise. A reset that happens twice a month is still a reset. A reset that happens for five minutes is still a reset.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

Plan around energy, not just time

Two open hours are not the same at 9 a.m. and 9 p.m. Time is on the calendar; capacity is in the body. A plan that ignores energy creates a to-do list that looks reasonable and feels impossible.

Three kinds of tasks

ENERGY	WHAT IT FEELS LIKE	TASKS THAT MIGHT FIT
High	Alert, warm, able to hold several steps	Appointments, paperwork, budgeting, difficult emails, cooking a new meal
Medium	Tired but functional, needs a clear next step	Laundry, dishes, groceries, routine replies, sorting one pile
Low	Foggy, sore, touched out, very little margin	Rest, medication you already take as prescribed, one dish, one email, a snack, asking for help

Your list will be different. The point is to stop assigning high-focus paperwork to your lowest-energy hour.

Use anchors instead of clock times

Clock times can slide past unnoticed. Anchors attach a task to something that already happens.

- After I make coffee, I open the calendar.
- When I plug in my phone, I check tomorrow's appointments.
- Before I sit down to watch something, I put one load of laundry in.
- When I get home, I put my keys in the same place.
- After dinner, I take two minutes for the reset note.

Make time visible

Time blindness is not solved by trying harder. Make the invisible more concrete:

- A visual timer or a kitchen timer.
- A clock within sight of the task.
- A "start at 6:40, stop at 7:00" window written on the page.
- A calendar alarm with a specific action, not just the word "admin."
- Body doubling: another person in the room, on a call, or on a focus timer with you.

> **The two-minute entry**
>
> If starting feels impossible, make the entry step absurdly small: open the document, put on the shoe, pick up one receipt, write the date. You are not committing to the whole task. You are proving it can start.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

A plan with buffers

Leave one blank block in the week. Not because you will definitely need it, but because something usually does. A buffer is not laziness. It is capacity planning.

My energy map

TIME OR ANCHOR	USUAL ENERGY	A REALISTIC TASK	WHAT WOULD MAKE IT EASIER?

Where the buffer goes

DAY OR TIME	WHAT MIGHT TAKE LONGER	THE BUFFER I WILL KEEP

A buffer can be ten minutes, a spare meal, a later start, or a deliberate “no.” It does not have to be a blank hour.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

Your gentle week

This is an undated page. Write the dates in the top row. Choose three priorities for each day — and one anchor that happens whether or not the priorities do.

The three priorities can be tiny. “Shower” is a priority on a hard day. “Send two emails” is a priority. “Rest” can also be a legitimate planned item, not the absence of a plan.

DAY / DATE	THREE PRIORITIES (OR ONE, HONESTLY)	ANCHOR	NOTES

The weekly non-negotiables

- ☐ Food is in the house.
- ☐ Prescriptions and essential appointments are handled.
- ☐ One bill or deadline checked.
- ☐ A little rest is on the calendar, not just “later.”
- ☐ Someone knows where I am if I am away.
- ☐ The plan can survive one bad day.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

My one anchor every day

An anchor is a small routine that tells your brain which part of the day it is. It is not a moral standard. Examples: morning medication with breakfast, ten minutes outside, a five-minute tidy-up, a message to one person, lights out at the same time.

What I will do when the day goes sideways

Write it now, while you are calm. A pre-decided response is easier than inventing one from the middle of a hard moment. Examples: drop the lowest priority, send “I need to move this,” order the easiest safe food, ask someone to sit with me, go to bed without “catching up.”

My back-up anchor

When the usual anchor is impossible, the back-up is:

Anchor check

- ☐ It takes under two minutes.
- ☐ It attaches to something that already happens.
- ☐ It is kind on a bad day.
- ☐ I will notice when it is missing.

> TRY THIS
>
> **Leave some white space**
>
> A page with air in it is easier to return to. You do not need to fill every square to have a valid week.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

The daily minimum

Some days are survival days. Some are steady. A few are good. Instead of one impossible standard, choose the version that matches the day, then stop moving the goalposts.

Survival day

The bar is care, not achievement.

- ☐ I took prescribed medication as directed, if I have one.
- ☐ I ate or drank something.
- ☐ I handled the smallest urgent thing.
- ☐ I told someone if I needed help.

My one kind thing today:

Steady day

A little forward motion, plus the basics.

- ☐ The survival basics.
- ☐ One 10-minute task from the list.
- ☐ One message or appointment handled.
- ☐ One reset gesture (dishes, trash, surface, laundry).

My 10-minute task:

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

Good day

Use the energy without spending all of it.

- ☐ The steady basics.
- ☐ One meaningful outcome.
- ☐ One thing that makes tomorrow easier.
- ☐ A deliberate stop time.

My meaningful outcome:

WATCH OUT

Do not use a good day to “pay back” a bad one

A burst of energy is not a debt settlement. If you spend every good day trying to repay the past, you will arrive at tomorrow with nothing left. Use some of the good day for the future, and keep some for now.

The after-check

At the end of the day, ask two questions. Not “Did I do enough?” That question has no useful answer. Instead:

01 What actually happened?

02 What would make the next hour slightly easier?

Answer in one line each, if that is all the energy you have.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

When the week falls apart

It will sometimes. A flare, a sick child, a work crisis, a depression dip, a lost phone, a plan that was too optimistic. A broken week is not a broken system, and it is not a reason to abandon the whole page.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **The reset does not require a fresh start**
>
> You do not need a new planner, a new month, or a dramatic Monday. You need the next small action. Keep the page with its crossings-out. It is a record, not a failure.

Triage the backlog

Sort every missed item into one of four moves:

MOVE	ASK	EXAMPLE
Drop	Does this actually matter now?	A non-essential organising project
Delay	Is there a real later date?	A routine appointment that can be rebooked
Delegate	Can someone else do it, or help?	Groceries, a ride, a two-person task
Shrink	What is the five-minute version?	One bill instead of the whole pile

If an item does not fit one of those moves, it is probably not a task. It may be a worry. Put it in a “think about later” box instead of letting it colonise the list.

The five-minute restart

- ☐ Set a timer for five minutes.
- ☐ Choose one item from the shrink column.
- ☐ Remove one obstacle: open the tab, find the phone number, get the envelope, move the laundry basket.
- ☐ Do only the first step.
- ☐ Stop when the timer ends, even if you feel like continuing.

Ask for help without a speech

Choose the sentence that fits. Change it so it sounds like you.

- “I’m having a low-capacity day. Could you take over [specific task]?”
- “I missed [thing]. Can we move it to [day/time]?”
- “I don’t need you to fix it. Could you sit with me while I make the call?”
- “I’m overwhelmed. Can you help me choose the first step?”
- “I need a 24-hour extension. Is that possible?”

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

My restart note

What happened (facts only):

The next smallest action:

What I am allowed to drop:

Who I can tell

When I will check in

DATE	TIME	THE ONE QUESTION I WILL ASK

What I will try differently

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

Your reset menu

A reset does not have to be twenty minutes. It can be shorter, and it still counts. Choose the version that fits the moment.

5 minutes

Pick one surface. Put away five things. Write tomorrow's first action on a sticky note. Stop.

15 minutes

Do the three-question check-in. Choose one outcome. Put one load of laundry in or clear one surface. Set one alarm.

45 minutes

Do the full reset ritual, plan the week's three outcomes, and make one thing easier for the next day — groceries ordered, clothes laid out, a message sent.

The keep-it-going checklist

- ☐ The reset page is where I will see it.
- ☐ Tomorrow has one starting point.
- ☐ There is at least one buffer in the week.
- ☐ I have a plan for the lowest-energy day.
- ☐ I know one person I can ask for help.
- ☐ Something has been deliberately left undone.

Three questions at the end of the week

Keep this short. A long review becomes another task to avoid.

01 **What worked?** Even if it was just "I opened the planner twice."

02 **What got in the way?** Name the obstacle, not your character.

03 **What should be smaller, different, or dropped next week?**

My three answers

TRY THIS

The goal is not a perfect routine

The goal is a routine that can be found again after it disappears. Leave a trail back to the page. Put it where you will bump into it, keep the pen nearby, and make the next version easier than the last.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 07

A week can be mostly Okay

Some weeks have a clean kitchen and three appointments and a lovely plan. Some weeks have clean socks and a phone call. Both are weeks you got through. The planner is not the judge; it is a landing pad.

The one-page takeaway

- Plan for the energy you have, not the energy you wish you had.
- Choose outcomes, then shrink the first step until it starts.
- Make the plan visible and the entry cheap.
- When the week breaks, triage before you moralise.
- Keep the version that helps; drop the ritual that becomes a chore.

My next small step

GOOD TO KNOW

A final permission slip

You do not have to become a different person to be helped by a piece of paper. You just need one place to put the next thing.

ONE LAST THING · 07

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Set a 20-minute appointment with yourself this week. Bring a pen, a calendar, and the truth about your energy — not the version of your week you wish you were having.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

A system should fit your real energy, not the other way around. Keep what helps, drop what becomes another chore, and let the next small step be enough.

More life-admin printables

- 08 The Paper Pile Triage Kit
- 09 Bills, Renewals & Subscriptions
- 10 The Appointment Companion
- 11 The Low-Energy Meal Plan
- 12 The Household Command Center

Free to use

Print these for yourself, your classroom, or a client. Please keep the credit and don't resell the files.

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.

PAPERWORK SYSTEM

The Paper Pile Triage Kit

Turn the pile into five decisions.

You do not need a filing cabinet, a label maker, or a personality transplant. You need a stopping point and five places for paper to go.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 A five-box triage method
02 A repeatable 15-minute session
03 A next-action worksheet
04 A simple paper and digital file map
05 Help for mail avoidance and the hard envelope

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

The pile is not a character flaw

Paper accumulates because every piece requires a decision: keep it, pay it, sign it, file it, call someone, or throw it away. When executive function is low, “I’ll deal with it later” is a completely understandable storage strategy. The problem is that later becomes a pile, and the pile becomes a source of dread.

The goal of this kit is not a Pinterest-perfect filing system. It is to reduce the number of open decisions in your home. You are allowed to have a messy drawer and a working system at the same time.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **Sort before you organise**
>
> Organising asks “Where should this live?” Triage asks “What is this and what happens next?” Do the second question first. Otherwise you will alphabetise the same unresolved paper three times.

Five principles

01 **One armful at a time.** The whole pile is not a task. One armful is a task.

02 **Decide, don’t perfect.** A rough category is enough for today.

03 **Write the next action.** “Deal with insurance” is not an action. “Call the number on page 2 and ask whether the claim was received” is.

04 **Keep sensitive paper out of sight.** Do not leave account numbers, medical papers, or identity documents on the kitchen table when company comes.

05 **Stop when the timer ends.** A repeatable 15 minutes beats a heroic four-hour session that leaves you unable to face paper for a month.

The only supplies you need

- A pen.
- A timer.
- A bin bag and a recycling bag.
- Five temporary boxes, trays, folders, or labelled spots on the floor.
- This printable.
- Optional: a phone for scanning, a folder for “needs action,” and a shredder or a plan for secure disposal.

You do not need to buy a label maker before you start. A sticky note counts as a label.

If the pile is in several places

Start where you look most often. That might be the kitchen counter, the entryway, or the passenger seat of your car. Pick one. The other piles can wait their turn.

Turning over the page is the first decision. That is enough to begin.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

The five-box sort

Label five temporary spots. The names can be rough. The behaviour matters more than the label.

1. Act now

Something with a real consequence in the next few days: a bill, a form with a deadline, an appointment letter, a renewal. Put it where you will see it, not in a drawer.

2. Date it

Something that matters later: a renewal notice, a ticket, a warranty, a seasonal notice. Write the date on the page or in your calendar.

3. File it

Something you may need again but do not need to act on: paid receipts, completed policies, closed accounts, reference letters.

4. Ask / verify

You do not know what it is, whether it is real, or what you are supposed to do. Put it in one place and write the question you need answered.

5. Release it

Obvious junk, duplicate copies, expired invitations, and anything you are genuinely finished with. Recycle the paper; shred what contains sensitive information.

The two-second question

For each item, ask only: **What is the next physical action?**

- If the answer is “put it in the action folder,” do that.
- If the answer is “write a date in my calendar,” do that.
- If the answer is “I don’t know,” put it in Ask / verify.
- If the answer is “nothing,” release it.

You do not have to complete the action during triage. Sorting is a separate job from doing. Trying to do both at once is how a 15-minute sort becomes a three-hour research project.

WATCH OUT

Protect sensitive documents

Do not write full account numbers, government ID numbers, passwords, or medical details on this printable. If a document contains those things, move it to a secure place and record only the action you need to take.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

What counts as done

A triage session is done when the timer rings, not when the pile disappears. If five papers have homes and three actions are written down, the session worked. Take the win before your brain decides it was not enough.

My five spots

BOX	WHERE IT WILL LIVE THIS WEEK	WHAT BELONGS HERE
Act now		
Date it		
File it		
Ask / verify		
Release		

A done-enough checklist

- ☐ Every Act now item is visible.
- ☐ Every Date it item has a date attached.
- ☐ Every Ask / verify item has a question written next to it.
- ☐ The Release bag has left the room.
- ☐ I wrote down one next action.
- ☐ I stopped when the timer said stop.

My rule for the next session

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

The 15-minute triage session

Use this page as your launch checklist. The session has three parts: set up, sort, and close. The close is what makes it repeatable.

Set up · 3 minutes

- ☐ Clear a table or a patch of floor.
- ☐ Put the bin, recycling, and five boxes within reach.
- ☐ Put your phone on silent, or use it only for the timer.
- ☐ Fill a glass of water.
- ☐ Decide one stopping point: one armful, one counter, or one drawer.
- ☐ Set the timer for 15 minutes.

Sort · 10 minutes

- ☐ Pick up one piece of paper.
- ☐ Ask: what is the next physical action?
- ☐ Put it in one of the five boxes.
- ☐ Do not open a new browser tab unless the paper cannot be understood without it.
- ☐ Do not start the action unless it takes under two minutes.
- ☐ Keep moving. Pauses to read every word are how the pile wins.
- ☐ When you find something emotional, put it in Ask / verify and keep sorting.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

Close · 2 minutes

- [ ] Put the File it box in its temporary home.
- [ ] Put the Act now papers where you will see them.
- [ ] Write the two or three actions you noticed in the action list on the next page.
- [ ] Move the Ask / verify pile to one folder or envelope.
- [ ] Put the Release bag by the door or in the bin.
- [ ] Write one sentence: what did this session actually clear?

My session close-out

Where the boxes go next

BOX	ITS NEXT HOME	WHEN IT MOVES
Act now		
Date it		
File it		
Ask / verify		
Release		

TRY THIS

Take a photo before you put it away

If you are worried you will forget what was in the pile, photograph the Act now and Ask / verify papers. The photo is a backup, not a second pile. Delete it once the action is handled.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

The next-action list

A paper pile usually hides a short list of actions. Use one line per action. Keep the description physical and small enough that a tired version of you could start it.

Actions found

ACTION (START WITH A VERB)	FOR WHICH PAPER?	DEADLINE OR CHECK DATE	DONE
Call and ask whether the claim was received	Insurance letter, page 2		☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐

If the action takes under two minutes

Do it now, while the paper is in your hand. Put the paper in Release or File it afterward. If it takes longer, write it down and move on. The two-minute rule is not a life philosophy; it is a way to stop small tasks from becoming invisible.

The follow-up date

Some actions wait on another person. Write the date you will check back. “Wait” is not a complete plan.

WAITING ON	CHECK BACK ON	WHAT I WILL DO IF THERE IS NO REPLY

The stop line

You do not need to complete every action today. Choose one. Put a dot beside it. That dot is your next contact with the paperwork, not another failure to finish it.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

A file map you can actually use

A filing system works when you can find something without remembering where you put it. Broad categories are easier to maintain than a perfect taxonomy. Start with six folders or six hanging files. Add detail only if you keep missing things.

The six starting folders

FOLDER	PUT THIS HERE	KEEP IN MIND
Home	Lease or deed, utilities, home insurance, repairs, warranties	Keep current insurance and lease or deed in a secure place.
Money	Bills, bank letters, tax documents, receipts you need	Do not write account numbers on the folder label.
Health	Visit summaries, test results, insurance notices, receipts	Store privately. Share only with people who help with your care.
Identity	Passport, birth certificate, Social Security or local ID papers, immigration documents	Use a locked or fire-resistant place. Check official replacement rules before mailing anything.
Work	Contracts, pay records, training certificates, retirement paperwork	Keep confidential work material separate from household paper.
Life misc.	Pets, school, travel, memberships, instructions, warranties	This is allowed to be a catch-all. A real system needs one.

My folder plan

FOLDER	WHERE IT WILL LIVE PHYSICALLY	WHERE IT WILL LIVE DIGITALLY
Home		
Money		
Health		
Identity		
Work		
Life misc.		

TRY THIS

Label the place, not just the folder

“Blue file box, top shelf” is easier to remember than “the filing cabinet.” Write the location somewhere you will see it when the folder is not in your hands.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

Physical or digital?

You do not need to scan everything. Scanning a whole archive can become another unfinished project. Choose by use:

- **Keep paper:** documents you are required to keep in original form, identity documents, and things you need to hand to another person.
- **Scan and file:** receipts you may need for reimbursement, instructions, warranties, and papers you want to reference but rarely need in original form.
- **Release:** duplicates, expired notices, and completed items that carry no continuing obligation.

A folder name that helps

“Important” is not a useful folder name, because everything feels important when you are overwhelmed. Use the situation instead: “Home – current lease,” “Money – taxes 2026,” “Health – visits and results,” “Work – current contract.”

My folder map

FOLDER OR BOX	PHYSICAL HOME	DIGITAL HOME	WHAT GOES IN

GOOD TO KNOW

Retention rules are local and specific

How long to keep tax, medical, employment, or property records depends on where you live and what the record is for. This page is a starting point, not legal or tax advice. Check an official source or a qualified professional before shredding documents with long-term consequences.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

Decode the envelope

The unknown is heavier than the task. Most mail becomes easier once you name what it is and what kind of response it needs. This table is a starting point, not instructions for your exact situation.

WHAT ARRIVED	WHAT IT USUALLY IS	A SENSIBLE FIRST MOVE
Bill or statement	A request for payment or a record of activity	Note the due date and the minimum action. Check it against what you expected before paying.
Insurance explanation of benefits	A statement of what was billed and paid — not always a bill	Check whether it says you owe something. If confused, call the number on the document.
Renewal notice	A reminder to renew or update something	Write the renewal date and the steps. Do not assume the price is unchanged.
Government form	A request for information or a notice of a decision	Read the deadline and the official contact channel. Verify the sender before sharing personal information.
Employment or benefits letter	A change, decision, or request for action	Note the date and who to contact. Keep a copy.
Legal or court notice	A document with legal consequences	Do not ignore it. Check the issuing office or seek qualified legal help. This kit cannot tell you what it legally means.
Collection notice	A claim that money is owed	Verify the sender and the debt before paying. Check official consumer resources or legal help if unsure.
Warranty or receipt	Proof of purchase or coverage	File it with the item's name and date. You rarely need to act immediately.
Invitation or event notice	A date and RSVP request	Decide now: yes, no, or ask. Then release the paper.
Anything that feels off	Could be legitimate, could be a scam	Do not use the contact details printed only on the letter. Look up the organisation independently.

When you do not know what it is

Use the Ask / verify box. Write three things on a sticky note and attach it:

01 What I think this is.

02 What I need to know.

03 Who or where can tell me the answer.

That turns a mysterious document into a small research task. It also stops it from floating back into the pile without a next step.

A phrase that saves time

"I received a notice and I'm not sure whether it requires action. Can you tell me what it is and what the deadline is?" This is a complete, respectful question. You do not need to apologise for not understanding the paperwork.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

Keep, scan, or shred

Paper decisions carry privacy and legal consequences. When in doubt, slow down. The safe answer is usually to keep the original until you verify the rule.

Before you shred

- ☐ Is it definitely a duplicate or a completed item with no ongoing obligation?
- ☐ Could it be needed for taxes, insurance, employment, immigration, a warranty, or a legal matter?
- ☐ Is it the only copy?
- ☐ Have I checked an official retention rule if I am unsure?
- ☐ Does it contain an account number, ID number, signature, or medical detail?

If you are unsure about any answer, put it in Ask / verify instead of shredding.

Sensitive paper

Identity documents, financial statements, medical records, and anything with an account number deserve more than the recycling bin. Use a shredder if you have one. If you do not, store the paper in a secure “to shred” bag and deal with it when you can, rather than leaving it visible in the bin.

Do not burn paper indoors or in unsafe conditions. Do not put sensitive documents in a shared recycling bin if secure disposal matters in your household.

Scanning without turning it into a project

01 Choose one small stack.
02 Scan or photograph with a scanning app.
03 Rename the file with a date and a plain description.
04 Put it in the right digital folder.
05 Mark the paper for secure disposal or file the original if it must be kept.
06 Stop at the end of the stack.

A useful file name: `2026-03-14 home insurance renewal.pdf`. A file name like `Scan_00473.pdf` is technically a file, but not a system.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

Digital safety basics

- Keep sensitive scans in a secure folder or encrypted storage if available.
- Do not send identity documents through ordinary chat or paste them into a consumer AI tool.
- Keep a backup of important digital files in a second place.
- Do not put passwords in the same folder as the documents they protect.

My secure-document plan

Where identity documents live:

Where sensitive paper waits for shredding:

Who else knows where the important documents are:

My digital checkup

- ☐ I know where identity documents live.
- ☐ Sensitive scans are in a secure folder.
- ☐ Important files have a second backup.
- ☐ Passwords are not stored beside the documents they protect.
- ☐ I know which account I will secure next.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

When the envelope is the hard part

Sometimes the task is not sorting. It is opening. A letter can carry a bill, a diagnosis, a rejection, a demand, or a reminder of something you have been avoiding. Avoiding it is a nervous-system response, not a personality defect.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **Open one. Do not solve one.**
>
> You are allowed to open an envelope without handling the contents. The goal of this first step is information, not resolution.

The lowest-barrier opening routine

- ☐ Sit somewhere comfortable with a bin and a pen.
- ☐ Put on a timer for five minutes.
- ☐ Open one envelope.
- ☐ Turn the letter face up and read only the first paragraph.
- ☐ Circle the sender and any date.
- ☐ Put it in Act now, Date it, or Ask / verify.
- ☐ Write one next action, or write “need help to understand this.”
- ☐ Stop.

If opening is still too much, ask someone you trust to sit with you while you do it. They do not have to read the letter. Their job is presence, not fixing.

If the paper is about money

Shame makes bills heavier. Try to separate the facts from the story:

- Fact: “There is a balance due on the 14th.”
- Story: “I am bad with money and everyone knows it.”

Only the fact is useful for planning. If the amount is unmanageable, contact the organisation and ask about options before the deadline. A brief phone call or message can be more effective than another week of avoidance. For legal, tax, or benefits advice, use a qualified professional or official service.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

If the paper is about health or care

You do not have to interpret it alone. Write down the question and call the clinic, insurer, or person who sent it. If you are supporting someone else, ask them what they want to know before you start reading.

My hard envelope plan

The envelope I have been avoiding:

The smallest opening step:

Who I can ask to sit with me:

The date I will try:

If the paper is about someone else

Ask what they want to know before you start reading. You are helping with the paperwork, not taking over the decision. Share only what they need and keep the original documents where they can find them.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

The quarterly 15-minute reset

The point of a system is not to prevent paper from ever building up. It is to make the return trip short. Once every season, spend fifteen minutes checking the places where paper goes to hide.

The quarterly checklist

- ☐ Clear the “Act now” papers that are already complete.
- ☐ Check the “Date it” box for dates that have passed.
- ☐ Move receipts and completed documents into File it.
- ☐ Look at the Ask / verify folder. Choose one question to resolve.
- ☐ Shred or securely dispose of the release paper.
- ☐ Check that identity and sensitive documents are in their secure place.
- ☐ Update the household command center if contact details or routines changed.
- ☐ Choose one thing to make easier next quarter.

The one-file fix

If the system has collapsed, do not rebuild the whole filing cabinet. Make one “current admin” folder with five subdivisions: Act, Date, File, Ask, and Release. Keep it next to the place where mail lands. When it fills up, do another triage session. A system that can be restarted is more useful than one that has to stay perfect.

My next audit date

What worked and what did not

I WANT TO KEEP DOING	I WANT TO STOP DOING	I WANT TO TRY ONCE

> TRY THIS
>
> **The pile is allowed to be smaller than the problem**
>
> A 15-minute session may not resolve the paperwork. It can still lower the noise, surface the urgent item, and give you a place to start next time. That is a real outcome.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 08

Paper is a tool, not a report card

You will not be graded on the filing cabinet. The useful question is not “Is everything organised?” It is “Can I find the thing I need when it matters?” A messy system that lets you find the insurance letter is better than a beautiful system you are afraid to touch.

The one-page takeaway

- Sort by next action before you try to organise.
- Use one armful and one timer.
- Put sensitive documents in a secure place.
- Keep the categories broad enough to maintain.
- Open one envelope before trying to solve one envelope.
- When unsure, verify before shredding.

My next small step

GOOD TO KNOW

A final permission slip

You do not owe anyone a perfect filing system. You owe future-you a fighting chance of finding the letter.

ONE LAST THING · 08

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Set a 15-minute timer and sort one armful of paper into the five boxes. Do not aim to finish the pile; aim to make one decision at a time.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

A system should fit your real energy, not the other way around. Keep what helps, drop what becomes another chore, and let the next small step be enough.

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.

MONEY ADMIN

Bills, Renewals & Subscriptions

Dates first. Shame later.

Not a budget makeover. A calmer map of what leaves your account, when it leaves, and what you can safely ignore until next month.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 A due-date map and autopay audit
02 A twelve-month renewal calendar
03 A subscription rescue plan
04 Scripts for tight months and cancellations
05 Privacy-safe AI prompts for money admin

PLAIN *ENGLISH* ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

Dates before amounts

Most money admin dread comes from not knowing what is coming. The amount matters, but the date is what turns a quiet week into a late fee. This planner starts with dates because a calendar is easier to face than a spreadsheet full of judgement.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **This is education, not financial advice**
>
> This guide helps you organise reminders and paperwork. It cannot decide what you can afford, which debt strategy is right for you, or how a local benefit works. For those decisions, use a qualified professional, a nonprofit credit counsellor, or an official government source. Never give a chatbot your bank login or card number.

Keep the sensitive numbers out

This sheet is designed to be useful without exposing your accounts. Write the biller and the due date. Use a nickname for the account if you need one. Do not write:

- Full account or card numbers.
- Passwords, PINs, or security answers.
- Your full government ID.
- Bank routing numbers.
- Screenshots of your banking app on a shared printer.

If you need the account number to call, look it up when you make the call. You do not need it copied onto a page that might sit on the kitchen table.

Three useful distinctions

Fixed vs. variable

Rent is fixed. A utility bill moves with the season. Variable bills need a reminder before the due date, not just a set-and-forget autopay.

Essential vs. flexible

Essential costs protect housing, food, health, transport, and basic connection. Flexible costs are real, but can often move or pause in a tight month. Sort without judging.

Autopay vs. autopilot

Autopay can prevent a late fee. Autopilot can hide a price increase for years. A good system checks both the payment and the amount.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

The four-part routine

01 **Map:** list the biller, due date, payment method, and where the statement lives.

02 **Check:** once a month, confirm autopays cleared and amounts are plausible.

03 **Calendar:** put annual renewals and variable bills where they will actually be seen.

04 **Reset:** once a quarter, question one subscription and update one contact detail.

That is the whole system. It does not require a colour-coded budget binder. It requires a place to look.

What this planner is not

It is not a complete financial plan. It is not a record of every purchase. It is not a substitute for a bank statement. It is the layer that helps you stop being surprised by the same six dates every month.

My version of the routine

PART	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE HERE	WHEN I WILL DO IT
Map		
Check		
Calendar		
Reset		

The one part I will start with

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

The due-date map

Fill in the bills that repeat. Use the due date or the typical day. If autopay is on, verify it in the source account — do not assume it is still working because you set it up years ago.

BILL OR PAYMENT	DUE DAY	HOW IT IS PAID	AUTOPAY?	WHERE I CHECK IT	LAST CONFIRMED
Housing					
Utilities					
Phone / internet					
Insurance					
Prescriptions / health costs					
Debt minimums					
Subscriptions					
Other					
Other					

The week-before check

Choose one day each month — payday, a quiet Sunday, or the same day as another routine. Spend ten minutes on these five checks.

- ☐ Look at the next two weeks of due dates.
- ☐ Confirm the money for automatic payments is available.
- ☐ Check for price changes or unusual amounts.
- ☐ Look for a bill that never arrived.
- ☐ Move one action to the calendar if it needs a call.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

If a bill is missing

A missing bill is not a free month. Check the provider’s app or website, your email spam folder, or the last statement. If the account normally arrives by post and it has not, contact the provider. Do not wait for a late fee to prove the point.

> TRY THIS
>
> **The two-place rule**
>
> Put the due date in your calendar and keep one visible list. Two places are easier to trust than a system so clever you cannot remember where the system is. If the calendar and the list disagree, the provider’s statement wins.

My monthly check day

Bills that need a phone call

BILLER	WHAT I NEED TO ASK	PHONE OR CONTACT	BEST TIME TO CALL

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

The autopay audit

Autopay is a tool, not a personality. It reduces effort and can also hide drift: a subscription renews at a new price, a bill gets charged twice, or a card expires and the payment silently fails. A short audit turns autopilot back into a choice.

Once a month

- ☐ Log in to the payment account directly, not through an email link.
- ☐ Scan the last 30 days for recurring charges.
- ☐ Match each charge to a bill or subscription.
- ☐ Flag anything you do not recognise.
- ☐ Check that the funding source is current.
- ☐ Look for duplicate services doing the same job.
- ☐ Note any amount that changed.

Once a year

- ☐ Recheck insurance, phone, internet, software, storage, and memberships.
- ☐ Look at the renewal price, not only the introductory price.
- ☐ Check whether a free trial will become a paid plan.
- ☐ Confirm the cancellation window and process.
- ☐ Update the card or account if it has changed.

The failed-payment checklist

If an autopay fails, deal with the payment first and the feelings second. Banks and providers can charge fees that grow quickly.

01 Confirm what failed and when.

02 Make the payment manually if it is safe and possible.

03 Check whether the provider charges a late fee or reports the missed payment.

04 Update the expired card or insufficient balance issue.

05 Turn on an earlier reminder for next month.

If a failed payment leads to a service shutoff or a debt you cannot manage, contact the provider or a qualified local service. Do not use a high-cost “fix” from an unsolicited message.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

My autopay rules

- ☐ Every recurring charge is listed on the due-date map.
- ☐ Automatic payments have at least a small buffer in the account.
- ☐ I know how to cancel each service I pay for.
- ☐ I check for trial-to-paid conversions after signing up.
- ☐ I review one old subscription every quarter.

One charge I will investigate

GOOD TO KNOW

You can turn autopay off

If an automatic payment is causing anxiety, you are allowed to switch to manual payments with calendar reminders — as long as you have a plan for the due date. There is no single correct method. There is only a method you will check.

My autopay review

BILL OR SERVICE	WHERE I CHECK IT	HOW OFTEN	NEXT CHECK

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

The renewal calendar

Annual renewals are easy to forget because they do not happen often enough to become routine. Put them in one place. Add the date you expect the charge, the likely amount, and the action you need to take before it renews.

MONTH	RENEWAL OR ANNUAL COST	EXPECTED AMOUNT	CHECK ON	ACTION
January				
February				
March				
April				
May				
June				
July				
August				
September				
October				
November				
December				

Renewals people often miss

- Insurance policies, unless escrowed or bundled.
- Professional licences, registrations, and certifications.
- Domain names, website hosting, and email services.
- Cloud storage and software plans.
- Memberships, warehouse clubs, and annual passes.
- Subscriptions bought for a single project.
- Warranties or service plans that auto-renew.
- Season passes, tickets, and pre-paid plans.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

The 30-day rule

Put a calendar reminder 30 days before a known annual renewal. At the reminder, answer three questions:

01 Do I still use this?

02 Has the price changed?

03 If I want to cancel or switch, what is the deadline and process?

If the answer is “I don’t know,” the reminder becomes a small research task: find the renewal terms and the cancellation route. That is enough for today.

The renewal note

SERVICE	RENEWAL DATE	PRICE LAST YEAR	PRICE THIS YEAR	KEEP / CANCEL / COMPARE

TRY THIS

Add the renewal to your calendar as an appointment

“Check car insurance” is easier to act on than “insurance stuff.” Put the specific action in the calendar event, along with a link to the account page or the phone number.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

The subscription rescue

Subscriptions are designed to be frictionless to start and slightly awkward to stop. A rescue is not about cancelling everything. It is about making the cost visible and choosing what earns its place.

Step 1 · Find them

Check three places:

- **Bank and card statements:** look for small recurring charges, annual renewals, and app-store charges.
- **App store subscriptions:** many in-app plans are billed there, not by the company directly.
- **Email inbox:** search for “receipt,” “renewal,” “subscription,” and “trial.”

Step 2 · Sort into three piles

KEEP	PAUSE / COMPARE	CANCEL
I use it most weeks and the current price makes sense.	I use it occasionally, or the price changed, or I need to compare a better option.	I forgot it existed, it no longer fits, or the free alternative is enough.

Step 3 · Cancel without a scavenger hunt

01 Find the service in the source where it is billed — app store, website, or provider account.

02 Look for Subscription, Billing, Plan, or Manage membership.

03 Check whether cancellation is immediate or runs to the end of the paid period.

04 Save the confirmation email or screenshot.

05 Remove the payment method from the service if that is available and appropriate.

06 Put a calendar note to check that no further charge appears.

If a service makes cancellation difficult, check the provider’s official help pages and your local consumer protection resources. Do not use a “cancellation service” that asks for your banking password.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

Step 4 · Make the keep decision honest

A subscription can be worth it even if you do not use it every day. The question is not “Am I using this enough to deserve it?” It is “If I were signing up today, would I choose this at this price?” If the answer is no, pause or cancel.

My one rescue action

WATCH OUT

Free trials are still financial commitments

Put the cancellation date in your calendar the day you start a trial — not when you remember. If a trial requires a card, decide now whether you actually intend to keep the paid plan.

The keep question

SUBSCRIPTION	WOULD I SIGN UP AGAIN TODAY AT THIS PRICE?	KEEP / PAUSE / CANCEL	NEXT STEP

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

The tight month

When money is short, the goal is not to create a perfect plan under pressure. It is to protect the essentials, buy time where you can, and avoid decisions that make next month worse.

This page is organisation, not financial advice. Local programs, legal protections, and benefit rules vary. Use an official service or qualified adviser for your specific situation.

GOOD TO KNOW

Stop and get qualified help if

You are facing eviction, foreclosure, utility shutoff, legal action, or a debt you cannot manage; you are considering a high-cost loan or a “debt relief” offer; or you are skipping food or medicine to pay something else. Contact a local emergency service, a nonprofit credit counsellor, or an official benefits office. Do not rely on a chatbot for this.

Sort the month into three lanes

PROTECT	PAUSE OR REDUCE	ASK ABOUT
Housing, food, health care, basic transport, essential utilities, minimum payments that carry serious consequences	Subscriptions, memberships, optional upgrades, non-urgent purchases	Payment plans, hardship programs, grace periods, local assistance, billing errors

The contact script

Use the phone or official website on your bill or statement. Do not use the contact details from an unexpected text message.

> “I’m having difficulty paying this bill. I want to understand my options before the due date. Can you tell me about payment plans, a due-date change, or hardship assistance? What do you need from me, and will this affect my account?”

Write down the date, the person or reference number, and what they said. If you are not sure the answer is right, ask them to send it in writing or point you to the official policy.

The “do not make it worse” list

- Do not ignore a shutoff or legal notice because it is frightening.
- Do not take a high-interest loan without understanding the total repayment.
- Do not pay an unsolicited “debt fixer” upfront.
- Do not share bank passwords with anyone who offers to sort it for you.
- Do not use AI to invent eligibility or legal claims.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

My tight-month plan

What is protected first:

Who I need to contact, and by when:

What I am pausing or cancelling:

Who can help me review this:

Calls to make

WHO	ABOUT	BY WHEN	DONE
			☐
			☐
			☐

What I am not deciding today

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

Ask AI without oversharing

AI can be useful for the organisational layer of money admin: building a bill calendar from dates you type, explaining a fee in plain English, drafting a call script, or turning a list into a checklist. It cannot verify your balance, access your bank, or make a financial decision for you.

WATCH OUT

The privacy line

Never paste bank logins, full account or card numbers, routing numbers, government IDs, security answers, or screenshots of your banking app into a general consumer AI tool. Redact names and exact account details. Use rounded amounts if you need help planning.

Prompt: build a reminder schedule

PROMPT RECIPE — TURN DATES INTO A REMINDER PLAN

Here is a list of recurring bills with only the names, due days, and whether the amount is fixed or variable. Do not ask for account numbers or balances.

Bills:
- [bill name] — due day [number] — [fixed/variable]
- [bill name] — due day [number] — [fixed/variable]

Make me a monthly reminder checklist. For each bill, say what to verify one week before the date. Put annual renewals in a separate list. Keep it to one page and do not invent any amounts.

Prompt: understand a fee

PROMPT RECIPE — EXPLAIN THIS CHARGE WITHOUT FINANCIAL ADVICE

I received this description of a fee: [paste only the generic description, with names and account numbers removed]. Explain what this kind of fee usually means in plain English, what questions I should ask the provider, and what information I should have ready. Do not tell me whether to pay it.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

Prompt: draft a call script

PROMPT RECIPE — PREPARE ME FOR A BILLING CALL

I need to call [provider type] about [problem]. I want to ask about [payment plan / due date / billing error / cancellation]. I am not asking for financial advice. Give me a short opening line, five questions to ask, what written confirmation to request, and a place to record the answer. Do not invent policy details or eligibility rules.

Before the call

- ☐ I have the bill or statement in front of me.
- ☐ I know the date of service or the account nickname.
- ☐ I know the one question I need answered.
- ☐ I have a pen and somewhere to record the answer.
- ☐ I know what I will do if they cannot help today.

The call record

DATE	WHO I SPOKE TO	REFERENCE	WHAT THEY SAID	NEXT STEP

Verify before you act

AI may be outdated, wrong, or confident about a rule that does not exist. Check the provider's official website, your statement, or a qualified human. The useful output is a clearer question or a better list — not an authority.

My safe AI use rule

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

The 15-minute monthly reset

Put this on the calendar as an appointment. Fifteen minutes once a month is enough to catch most avoidable surprises. If fifteen minutes is too much, do the first five.

Minutes 0–5 · Look

- ☐ Open the due-date map.
- ☐ Check the next 30 days.
- ☐ Scan recent recurring charges.
- ☐ Notice anything unrecognised or newly expensive.

Minutes 5–10 · Act

- ☐ Schedule one necessary call or payment.
- ☐ Cancel or pause one thing that no longer earns its place.
- ☐ Update one renewal date or contact detail.
- ☐ Move one action into the calendar with a specific verb.

Minutes 10–15 · Close

- ☐ Write what changed.
- ☐ Put the sheet back where you will see it.
- ☐ Choose the next reset date.
- ☐ Stop.

The monthly reset log

MONTH	ONE THING CHECKED	ONE THING CHANGED	NEXT RESET

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

The low-energy version

If a full reset is impossible, choose one:

- Check the next due date.
- Verify one autopay.
- Cancel one subscription.
- Open one bill and write one action.
- Ask someone to sit with you while you make one call.

A partial check is still a check. The goal is not to become the kind of person who loves financial admin. The goal is to hear the due date before it becomes a late fee.

The one thing I will do

What I will ask someone else to do

My next small step

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 09

Enough awareness to breathe

Money admin is not a measure of your worth. It is a set of recurring logistics that can be made more visible, more predictable, and less personal. A due-date map and a fifteen-minute appointment will not solve every financial problem. They can stop the same surprise from arriving every month.

The one-page takeaway

- Dates first; amounts can follow.
- Keep account numbers off worksheets.
- Autopay needs an audit, not blind trust.
- Put annual renewals in a calendar with a specific action.
- In a tight month, protect the essentials and ask early.
- Use AI for wording and organisation, never for bank access or decisions.

My next small step

GOOD TO KNOW

A final permission slip

You do not need to love money admin to be good at one small part of it. Start with the next date.

ONE LAST THING · 09

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Open your last statement or banking app and copy only the rounded recurring amounts and due dates onto the due-date map. Never write full account numbers on this sheet.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

A system should fit your real energy, not the other way around. Keep what helps, drop what becomes another chore, and let the next small step be enough.

More life-admin printables

- 07 The Low-Energy Weekly Reset
- 08 The Paper Pile Triage Kit
- 10 The Appointment Companion
- 11 The Low-Energy Meal Plan
- 12 The Household Command Center

Free to use

Print these for yourself, your classroom, or a client. Please keep the credit and don't resell the files.

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.

HEALTH ADMIN

The Appointment Companion

Prepare less frantically. Remember more clearly.

This is a paperwork companion, not a medical guide. It helps you walk in prepared and walk out with the next step written down.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 A one-page appointment prep sheet
02 Questions that get clearer answers
03 After-visit and results trackers
04 Refill, referral, and insurance routines
05 Clear rules for AI health admin

PLAIN *ENGLISH* ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

Prepare without panicking

Appointments move fast. You wait weeks, then sit in a bright room and try to remember the one thing you needed to ask while someone types. Later, you are handed instructions you did not fully absorb. This planner exists to make that sequence less brittle.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **This is education, not medical advice**
>
> This companion helps with preparation and organisation. It does not diagnose, treat, or tell you to change medication. Follow the instructions from your own care team. If you think you are having an emergency, contact your local emergency number or emergency service now.

Before you start

- Use a pen and this page, or your phone's notes app.
- Have your appointment date, time, location, and clinician's name nearby.
- Keep your medication list and insurance card where you can find them.
- Decide whether you want someone with you for support.
- Do not paste private health records into a consumer AI tool while preparing.

What "prepared" means

It does not mean knowing everything. It means bringing the facts you have, naming what you need, and leaving with the next step in writing. That is enough.

Bring

Appointment details, medication list, insurance or payment information, questions, a pen, and a way to take notes.

Ask

What is happening? What are the options? What happens next? Who do I contact? What should I watch for? Write the answers down.

Leave with

The next appointment, any referral, test instructions, medication changes (if any), and a phone number for follow-up questions.

A note on notes

You can ask, "May I record this so I can remember it?" Some clinics allow it and some do not. Ask first. If recording is not allowed, ask the clinician to slow down or write the key points for you. Taking notes on paper is allowed and useful.

If you are supporting someone

Ask the person what they want help with before the appointment. They may want you to take notes, ask a specific question, drive, or simply be present. Being in the room is not permission to speak for them. Agree on a signal for "please step in" and one for "I've got this."

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

The appointment prep sheet

Fill this in once, then bring it with you. Use short phrases. You do not need complete sentences.

The basics

APPOINTMENT	DATE AND TIME	CLINICIAN OR SERVICE	LOCATION / PHONE

Why I am going

Write the main reason in one sentence. Then list any changes since the last visit: symptoms, sleep, appetite, mood, pain, function, or side effects. Keep it descriptive; you do not need to diagnose it.

What I need to tell them

- ☐ A new or worsening problem.
- ☐ A medication question or side effect.
- ☐ A change in insurance, pharmacy, or address.
- ☐ A result or referral I do not understand.
- ☐ Something I have been avoiding mentioning.
- ☐ A practical barrier: transport, cost, time, caregiving, accessibility.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

Questions I want answered

Choose the three that matter most. You can add more later if there is time.

MY QUESTION	THE ANSWER (LEAVE BLANK UNTIL THE VISIT)
1.	
2.	
3.	

Getting there

TRANSPORT PLAN	TIME TO LEAVE	SUPPORT PERSON	WHAT I NEED TO BRING

TRY THIS

Put the appointment in two places

Add it to your calendar with the address and a travel alarm, then put the appointment card or note where you will see it. For an early appointment, set out clothes and paperwork the night before.

What I need to bring

- ☐ Appointment details and any paperwork they asked for.
- ☐ Medication list, if I take anything regularly.
- ☐ Insurance or payment information.
- ☐ My top three questions.
- ☐ A pen and paper, or a note-taking plan.
- ☐ Water, a snack, or anything that makes waiting easier.

One question I almost left out

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

Ask until it is clear

You are allowed to ask questions. You are allowed to ask the same question in a different way. You are allowed to say that you did not understand. This is not being difficult; it is part of getting safe care.

Six questions worth keeping

01 **What do you think is going on?** Ask for the explanation in plain language.

02 **What are the options, including doing nothing or waiting?** Ask about the trade-offs.

03 **What is the next step, and who does it?** Make the action and owner concrete.

04 **How will we know whether it is working?** Ask about follow-up and warning signs.

05 **What should I do if the plan is not working or I get worse?** Write the answer down.

06 **Can you write the key points down for me?** This is a reasonable request.

The teach-back

Before you leave, say: “Can I repeat this back to make sure I have it?” Then explain the plan in your own words. This helps catch a misunderstanding while you are still in the room. You can also ask a support person to repeat it.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **“I don’t understand” is a complete sentence**
>
> If an explanation is full of terms, ask: “What does that mean in everyday words?” or “Can you say that again more slowly?” A clinician would rather explain than have you leave confused.

Writing the answer

Do not rely on memory alone. Write the answer next to the question, even in messy shorthand. If you take notes in a phone, create one note per appointment. If someone comes with you, ask them to capture the practical details while you focus on the conversation.

When you need to interrupt

If you are overwhelmed, breathe and say: “I’m getting overwhelmed. Can we pause for a second?” If you need the room quieter, a break, a written summary, or a support person, ask. A short pause is better than leaving with information you cannot use.

My question for next time

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

After the visit

The most useful ten minutes of an appointment can happen right after it ends. Sit somewhere quiet, before the details blur, and write four things: the plan, the next action, the follow-up, and who to call.

The ten-minute capture

- ☐ What is the main plan in one sentence?
- ☐ What changes, if any, were made to my care routine?
- ☐ What do I need to do next, and by when?
- ☐ What tests, referrals, or appointments were ordered?
- ☐ Who do I call with a question?
- ☐ What warning signs or instructions did they give me?
- ☐ What did I not understand?

My visit summary

WHAT WE DISCUSSED	WHAT HAPPENS NEXT	BY WHEN	WHO I CONTACT

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

Follow-up and referrals

APPOINTMENT OR REFERRAL	ORDERED ON	SCHEDULING CONTACT	APPOINTMENT DATE	DONE
				☐
				☐
				☐

The next appointment

DATE	TIME	LOCATION	WHAT TO BRING	TRANSPORT PLAN

WATCH OUT

If instructions conflict or something feels wrong

Do not guess. Contact the care team that gave you the instructions, or use the after-hours number they provided. If you think it is an emergency, contact your local emergency number. This printable cannot tell you what is medically right.

My one unresolved question

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

Tests, results, and the waiting gap

Waiting for a result can turn every day into a low hum of dread. This page does not make the result arrive faster. It gives the wait a container and makes it less likely that a follow-up falls through.

The result tracker

TEST OR SCAN	DATE DONE	WHERE RESULT WILL APPEAR	HOW I WILL BE TOLD	FOLLOW-UP DATE	DONE
					☐
					☐
					☐
					☐

The waiting plan

Choose what you will do while waiting. This is not about distraction at all costs; it is about giving the anxious part of your brain a known next checkpoint.

- ☐ I know when to expect the result.
- ☐ I know how the result will reach me.
- ☐ I know who to call if it does not arrive.
- ☐ I have a follow-up date in my calendar.
- ☐ I have one small thing to do on the day the result is due.
- ☐ I have someone I can check in with.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

When the result arrives

Do not try to interpret a result by yourself from a number on a screen. Write down what the result says, whether your care team has reviewed it, and what they told you to do next. If you do not understand a word or a range, ask. Online explanations may not apply to your situation.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **A result is not a diagnosis by itself**
>
> Test results need context: why the test was ordered, your history, and what your care team is looking for. An AI chatbot does not have that context and cannot safely interpret your result for you.

If nobody calls

If the expected date passes, use the contact route your clinic gave you. A short message is enough: “I had [test] on [date]. I was told results would be available by [date]. Can you tell me whether they have been reviewed and what the next step is?” Record the response.

My result-day plan

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

Refills, pharmacy, and the repeat stuff

Refills fail for boring reasons: the bottle ran out on a Sunday, the pharmacy needs a new prescription, the insurance changed, or the automatic refill was never set up. A small routine prevents the last-minute scramble.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **Medication changes belong to your care team**
>
> This page helps you track and request refills. It does not advise starting, stopping, or changing a medication. If you are worried about a medication or a side effect, contact your clinician or pharmacist. Do not change how you take a prescribed medicine based on a chatbot's answer.

The refill routine

- ☐ Know the pharmacy name, address, phone, and hours.
- ☐ Know which medications need a new prescription before the pharmacy can refill.
- ☐ Check the label for refills remaining and the next eligible refill date.
- ☐ Put a refill reminder 5–7 days before you expect to run out.
- ☐ Request refills through the pharmacy's official app, phone line, or in person.
- ☐ Keep a current medication list with doses exactly as prescribed.
- ☐ Ask about refill synchronization if you have several prescriptions.

The medication list

Keep this page where you keep your appointment notes, and take it to appointments. Do not rely on memory if you take several medicines or have had recent changes.

MEDICATION (AS PRESCRIBED)	DOSE ON LABEL	HOW I TAKE IT	PRESCRIBER	PHARMACY	NOTES

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

If the pharmacy says there is a problem

Write down exactly what they say before you panic. Common issues include:

- Refills remaining: 0 — a new prescription may be needed.
- Too soon to refill — check the date you are eligible.
- Insurance or prior authorization issue — ask what the next step is.
- Out of stock — ask when it will arrive or whether another pharmacy has it.
- Different formulation or dose — do not accept a change without confirming with the prescriber.

The travel and emergency plan

If you will be away from home, ask your pharmacy about an early refill or a vacation supply, and check the rules that apply to your medication. Keep medication in its labelled container. Do not transfer it into an unlabeled pill organizer for travel.

My refill reminder

My pharmacy details

PHARMACY	PHONE	HOURS	REFILL LINE OR APP

What I will ask when I call

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

Insurance paper, medical bills, and the phone call

Health paperwork has its own vocabulary. You do not need to become an expert. You need to know what the paper is asking, whether it is a bill, and what the next step is.

Three documents that look alike

DOCUMENT	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS	WHAT TO CHECK
Explanation of benefits (EOB)	A statement of what was billed, allowed, and paid. It is often not a bill.	Whether it says “You owe,” and whether the amount matches what you expected.
Provider bill	A request for payment from a clinic or hospital.	The date of service, the amount, and whether insurance has processed the claim.
Insurance denial or request for information	The plan needs more information or has declined coverage.	The reason, the deadline, the official appeal process, and who can help.

Before you pay a medical bill

- ☐ Confirm it is a bill, not an EOB.
- ☐ Check the patient name, date, and service.
- ☐ Compare it with the EOB if you have one.
- ☐ Ask for an itemised bill if the charges are unclear.
- ☐ Ask whether the claim has been processed by insurance.
- ☐ Ask about financial assistance, payment plans, or a prompt-pay discount.
- ☐ Write down the reference number and the date you called.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

A clear phone script

> “I received a statement for [service] on [date]. I want to confirm whether this is a bill and whether the insurance claim has been processed. Can you explain the amount and send me an itemised statement? I would also like to know about payment plans or financial assistance.”

Do not share payment information with someone who calls you unexpectedly. Hang up and use the number on your official statement or the insurer’s website.

GOOD TO KNOW

Appeals and coverage rules are specific

Appeal deadlines, coverage rules, and financial assistance programs vary. Ask the insurer, the provider, or a qualified patient advocate for the official process. This guide is education, not legal or benefits advice.

Before the call

- ☐ The statement or letter is in front of me.
- ☐ I know the date of service and the amount in question.
- ☐ I know whether I am asking about a bill, an EOB, or a denial.
- ☐ I have a pen and a place to write the reference number.
- ☐ I know the next step if this office cannot help.

The call record

DATE	WHO I SPOKE TO	REFERENCE	WHAT THEY SAID	NEXT STEP

My paperwork note

DOCUMENT	DATE	AMOUNT	WHAT IT IS	NEXT STEP

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

AI can help with the admin, not the medicine

AI is useful for the organisational and language parts of health admin. It is not a clinician, does not know your history, and can invent details with confidence. Keep the line clear.

Fair uses

- Turn a list of dates into an appointment tracker.
- Suggest questions to ask your clinician.
- Rewrite a confusing insurance letter in plain language.
- Draft a polite scheduling or billing message.
- Help you make a checklist for what to bring.
- Practise saying “I need to understand the next step.”

Not safe uses

- Interpreting a test result or scan.
- Diagnosing a symptom.
- Starting, stopping, or changing medication.
- Deciding whether an emergency is “real enough.”
- Uploading private records to a consumer tool without understanding the settings.
- Letting AI write a message that claims something happened when it did not.

WATCH OUT

Do not paste what you would not want exposed

A health record can contain your name, date of birth, provider, diagnosis, and insurance details. Use placeholders. If you need help understanding a real document, ask the provider or insurer, or use a tool your care team has approved.

Prompt: prepare for an appointment

PROMPT RECIPE — HELP ME PREPARE, WITHOUT DIAGNOSING

I have an appointment about [general concern]. Ask me up to five questions to help organise what I want to say. Then give me a short prep sheet with: my main concern, changes to mention, three questions for the clinician, and what I should write down during the visit. Do not suggest a diagnosis or a treatment. Remind me to confirm every next step with my care team.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

Prompt: understand an official letter

PROMPT RECIPE — MAKE THIS ADMIN LETTER EASIER TO ACT ON

Rewrite the following generic sentence from an insurance or clinic letter in plain English: [paste a sentence with all names, IDs, and dates removed]. List the action it seems to require and three questions I should ask the sender. Do not guess the policy or tell me what the letter legally means.

Prompt: draft a scheduling message

PROMPT RECIPE — DRAFT A CLEAR SCHEDULING MESSAGE

Write a short message to [clinic or service] asking about [appointment, referral, or bill]. Include my name placeholder, the date of service if relevant, and a request for the next step. Keep it polite and under 120 words. Do not invent any medical details or claim that I have already done something.

My AI boundary

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

A small health-admin kit

You do not need a complete medical binder. You need a place where the next appointment, the current medication list, the latest result, and the insurance question can live together. Make the system smaller than the chaos.

The folder

Create one physical folder or one secure digital folder called “Health admin — current.” Inside, keep:

- Appointment cards and recent visit summaries.
- The current medication list.
- Results and letters you are waiting on.
- Insurance and billing papers that need action.
- A single page of current questions.

Review it before an appointment and after one. Once a quarter, remove papers you no longer need and check that the medication list is current.

The monthly five-minute check

- ☐ Any appointment in the next two weeks?
- ☐ Any test result or referral waiting?
- ☐ Any medication or refill due?
- ☐ Any bill or insurance letter unresolved?
- ☐ Any question I want to remember to ask?

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 10

My health-admin home

Physical folder location:

Secure digital folder or password manager note name (never the password):

Person who knows where it is, if that is useful:

TRY THIS

One question is enough

If you only bring one question to an appointment, bring the one that would change what you do next. Write it at the top of the page. The rest can wait.

My next small step

GOOD TO KNOW

A final reminder

Preparation is not a substitute for care. It is a way to make the care you receive easier to understand, follow, and remember.

ONE LAST THING · 10

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Pick your next appointment and fill in only the top three boxes: why you are going, your top question, and how you will get there. The rest can wait.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

A system should fit your real energy, not the other way around. Keep what helps, drop what becomes another chore, and let the next small step be enough.

More life-admin printables

- 07 The Low-Energy Weekly Reset
- 08 The Paper Pile Triage Kit
- 09 Bills, Renewals & Subscriptions
- 11 The Low-Energy Meal Plan
- 12 The Household Command Center

Free to use

Print these for yourself, your classroom, or a client. Please keep the credit and don't resell the files.

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.

HOME & MEALS

The Low-Energy Meal Plan

Food, without the daily committee meeting.

This is not a diet plan or a performance of domestic competence. It is a way to make the next meal easier to decide.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 A capacity-based meal map
02 A pantry and freezer inventory
03 A flexible theme week
04 A shopping list and micro-prep routine
05 A rescue plan for empty-tank nights

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Start with capacity, not aspiration

Meal planning often fails because it is designed for a calm Sunday person with a clean kitchen and unlimited executive function. The rest of us need a plan that can survive a Tuesday.

This kit assumes three things: decisions are tiring, appetites change, and “I’ll cook properly when I have time” is not a meal. The goal is not a perfectly balanced week. It is fewer moments of standing in front of the fridge feeling defeated.

> GOOD TO KNOW
>
> **Food is not a moral test**
>
> A sandwich, cereal, toast, frozen food, or takeout can be a legitimate meal. This planner is about reducing friction and expanding your options, not grading your plate. If you have a medical condition, food allergy, eating disorder, or prescribed diet, use the guidance of your own care team or a registered dietitian.

The capacity tiers

Zero effort

No cooking or only assembly. Frozen meal, ready-made soup, sandwich, cereal, crackers and cheese, leftovers, takeout, a snack plate.

Low effort

One pan, one pot, or one appliance. Pasta with jar sauce, rice and frozen vegetables, quesadillas, eggs on toast, microwave baked potato, a pre-marinated protein.

Some effort

Multiple steps or a longer cook. A recipe, a batch meal, a new dish, or anything that requires chopping several ingredients.

The three-question check

Before planning meals, ask:

01 **What do I actually have energy for this week?** Not what I wish I had.

02 **What food is already in the house?** Use that first.

03 **What are the danger windows?** Late evenings, shift days, medication changes, a child’s activity night, or the day before groceries.

Plan for the danger window before the ideal dinner. A backup meal in the freezer is worth more than a beautiful menu that assumes a calm evening.

Keep food safe

Basic food safety matters more than meal aesthetics. Keep hot food hot, cold food cold, refrigerate leftovers promptly, label and date containers, and follow guidance from local health authorities. When in doubt about whether food is safe, throw it out. This guide cannot assess your specific food.

The only rule

Make the next meal easier to decide. That is it. The rest of this planner is a menu of ways to do that.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

The three-tier meal map

Fill this in with meals you already know. Do not invent a new cuisine for a week that is already full. Familiar food has a lower executive-function cost.

Zero effort

No cooking, or assembly only. These are your “I cannot” meals.

MEAL	WHAT IT NEEDS	WHERE IT LIVES

Low effort

One pan or one appliance, under about 20 minutes. These are your “tired but possible” meals.

MEAL	MAIN INGREDIENTS	ONE SHORTCUT

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Some effort

Meals worth making when you have more capacity. These can become leftovers.

MEAL	WHY IT IS WORTH IT	BEST DAY FOR IT

The backup shelf

Choose three foods that can live in the cupboard or freezer and require almost no planning. They are not “emergency junk”; they are infrastructure.

02

TRY THIS

Name the meal, not the food group

“Toast with peanut butter” is easier to act on than “protein and carbs.” “Frozen dumplings and cucumber” is a meal. Specific is kind.

The leftover plan

MEAL	COOK ON	EAT AGAIN ON	HOW I WILL STORE IT

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

What is actually in the house

A pantry inventory is not a production. Walk to the kitchen and write what you see in broad groups. You are looking for the start of meals, not auditing a restaurant.

The five-minute inventory

CATEGORY	WHAT I CAN SEE	USE SOON?
Cans and jars		
Dry goods (pasta, rice, cereal, oats)		
Fridge basics		
Freezer		
Snacks and quick food		
Condiments and flavour		

The “what’s for dinner” decision tree

Start at the top and take the first exit that works. You do not have to reach the ideal answer.

01 Is there a leftover I can reheat? **Yes →** reheat it. **No →** go to 2.

02 Is there a frozen or ready-made meal I can heat? **Yes →** use it. **No →** go to 3.

03 Can I put a protein, a carb, and a vegetable together in one pan or plate? **Yes →** do that. **No →** go to 4.

04 Is there bread, eggs, noodles, rice, or a tortilla plus something to put on it? **Yes →** make the simplest version. **No →** go to 5.

05 Is takeout or delivery possible and affordable today? **Yes →** order without guilt. **No →** go to 6.

06 Is there a snack plate, cereal, or toast option? **Yes →** eat that. **No →** ask for help or use a local food resource.

The point of the tree is to stop the open-ended question. The first edible answer counts.

The grocery gap

Write down the three things that would turn several “nothing to eat” moments into meals. Examples: eggs, frozen vegetables, tortillas, rice, soup, yogurt, fruit that will survive the week.

01
02
03

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

A flexible theme week

Themes reduce decisions without requiring a recipe for every day. You can swap days freely. The theme is a suggestion, not a contract.

DAY / DATE	THEME	THE MEAL I MIGHT MAKE	BACKUP IF ENERGY DROPS
Monday			
Tuesday			
Wednesday			
Thursday			
Friday			
Saturday			
Sunday			

Theme ideas

THEME	WHAT IT CAN MEAN
Pasta night	Pasta with jar sauce, frozen vegetables, or whatever is in the fridge
Rice bowl	Rice or microwave rice, a protein, a sauce, and a vegetable
Toast night	Toast, eggs, beans, cheese, avocado, or leftovers on top
Soup and bread	Canned or frozen soup with bread or crackers
Breakfast for dinner	Eggs, pancakes, cereal, or whatever feels low-effort
Leftover night	Reheat what exists; add a new sauce or a piece of fruit
Takeout night	A planned night off from cooking, within your budget
Snack plate	Cheese, crackers, fruit, hummus, leftover protein, whatever is real

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

The rules for the week

- **Cook once, use twice.** If you make rice, pasta, or a protein, make enough for another meal.
- **Keep one night flexible.** Something will move.
- **Plan the danger window.** Put the zero-effort meal on the night that is usually hardest.
- **Do not schedule a new recipe on a low-capacity day.**
- **Leave one empty slot.** A blank day is not a failure; it is room to be human.

My danger window

The hardest meal of the week is:

The backup meal I will keep ready for it:

If the week is already full

- Choose the same breakfast for three days.
- Put the zero-effort meal on the two hardest nights.
- Buy one ready-made thing you actually like.
- Let lunch be a snack plate.
- Ask someone else to choose one dinner.

My one rule this week

What I am not doing

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

One list, three ways

A shopping list is a memory tool, not a test of adulthood. Keep it in one place. Use the same categories each time so your eyes know where to look.

The basic list

PRODUCE	PROTEIN AND DAIRY	DRY GOODS AND CANS	FROZEN	OTHER

Three ways to shop

By aisle

Organise the list by the route you walk. This reduces backtracking and decision fatigue.

By pickup

Order online for pickup. Add the list the day before, then choose a time that fits your energy. Check the substitutions before checkout.

By delivery

Use delivery when leaving the house is the barrier. Watch fees and the minimum order. A slightly more expensive grocery delivery can still be cheaper than another night of takeout plus stress.

The “do not forget” five

Pick five items that make the week work. Keep them in a visible note on your phone.

05 The overbuying guardrail

Buying quantities that will spoil is a common form of optimism. If produce often goes soft, buy frozen or pre-cut for the busiest days. A frozen vegetable that gets eaten is better than fresh produce that becomes guilt in the crisper drawer.

The receipt reset

After putting groceries away, circle the things you bought for a specific meal. If a meal no longer seems realistic, move its ingredients into the zero-effort or low-effort plan. The food does not have to follow the original plan.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Micro-prep and the no-prep-day

“Meal prep” often means spending a whole afternoon cooking, then eating the same container five times and losing interest. Micro-prep is smaller: do one thing that makes a future meal easier.

Ten-minute micro-prep ideas

- ☐ Wash or cut one fruit or vegetable that will otherwise spoil.
- ☐ Cook a pot of rice or pasta for later.
- ☐ Boil a few eggs.
- ☐ Divide a pack of meat into meal-sized portions and freeze promptly.
- ☐ Make one sauce or dressing.
- ☐ Put a frozen meal in the fridge to thaw for tomorrow, if the packaging allows.
- ☐ Label and date leftovers before they become a mystery.
- ☐ Put a ready-to-eat snack where you will see it.

The “one future meal” rule

After you cook, set aside one portion for a future version of you. It does not need to be a full batch. One extra bowl of soup, one extra serving of rice, one extra piece of chicken is enough.

My one prep task

The prep task:

When I will do it:

What will make it easier

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Basic leftover safety

Follow local food safety guidance for how long different foods can be kept. As a practical rule, cool leftovers promptly, refrigerate them in shallow containers, label them with the date, reheat them thoroughly, and throw them out when you are unsure. Do not rely on smell alone to decide whether a food is safe.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **This is not a food-safety course**
>
> Food handling rules vary, and some people are at higher risk from foodborne illness. Use official local guidance or ask a qualified professional if you are unsure. This planner is education, not medical or food-safety advice.

My micro-prep

The one thing I will do after the next shop:

The future meal I will set aside:

The prep-day alternative

If you like a big prep session, plan a short one: choose one protein, one grain, one vegetable, and one sauce. Store them separately so the week does not taste like the same meal five times. Stop before you are exhausted; a smaller prep you repeat is better than a heroic one you avoid.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Empty-tank rescue

The empty-tank night is not a character failure. It is a predictable part of life. Make the plan now, while you have a little more capacity.

The emergency meal formula

Pick one from each column, or just pick one thing.

BASE	FILLING	FLAVOUR OR CRUNCH
Bread, toast, tortilla, rice, noodles, potato	Egg, beans, cheese, leftover protein, frozen dumplings, soup	Sauce, salsa, yogurt, pickle, crispy onion, fruit

The takeout script

Ordering food is allowed. Make it easier:

- Keep delivery or pickup options saved in a note.
- Decide a rough spending limit before you are hungry and depleted.
- Choose the order before opening the app, if possible.
- Check the delivery fee and minimum order before checkout.
- Put leftovers away promptly if the food is safe to keep.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

The snack-plate option

A snack plate is a meal when it contains enough to get you to the next meal. Try one protein or dairy, one carbohydrate, one fruit or vegetable, and something you actually enjoy. It does not need to look like a lunchbox.

The ask-for-help option

- “I don’t have the capacity to cook tonight. Could you handle dinner or choose takeout?”
- “Could you pick up [specific item] on the way home?”
- “I made too much [meal]. Would you like some?” or “Could I have some of what you made?”
- “Can you sit with me while I make the food?” Sometimes company lowers the activation barrier.

My rescue plan

My no-cook meal:

My takeout default and rough limit:

The person I can ask:

TRY THIS

Keep the rescue visible

Put one frozen meal, a takeout menu, or a snack-plate reminder where you will see it on a hard night. The plan cannot help if it is buried under the thing it was meant to solve.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Ask AI for meal-plan help, safely

AI can be a useful meal-planning assistant when you give it your real constraints. It can turn a list of food into meal ideas, build a shopping list, or suggest a low-effort version of a familiar dish. It is not a dietitian, and it cannot know your medical needs or food safety conditions.

WATCH OUT

Keep health and privacy boundaries

Do not paste medical records, full names, addresses, or a child's identifying information into a consumer AI tool. If you have a prescribed diet, allergies, diabetes, kidney disease, or a history of disordered eating, use your care team's guidance rather than a chatbot's meal plan. Verify ingredients and allergens yourself.

Prompt: turn what I have into meals

PROMPT RECIPE — BUILD MEALS FROM THIS LIST

I have these ingredients: [list generic ingredients].
My equipment is: [microwave, one pan, oven, etc.].
My energy level is: [zero / low / some].
I like: [flavours or meals]. I avoid: [allergies or ingredients].
Give me five meal ideas that use what I have, with a zero-effort backup.
Do not give medical or nutrition advice. Ask me up to three questions
if something important is missing.

Prompt: build a gentle week

PROMPT RECIPE — MAKE A LOW-DECISION MEAL WEEK

Create a seven-day dinner plan using meals I already know:
[familiar meals].
I have capacity for [number] cooking nights. I want at least two no-cook
or leftover nights. I do not want a new recipe on [hard day].
Make a shopping list grouped by grocery section. Do not invent health
benefits or tell me what I should eat for a medical condition.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Prompt: make the backup plan

PROMPT RECIPE — DESIGN A NO-COOK BACKUP

I want a backup meal for the nights when I cannot cook. I have a [microwave / kettle / fridge] and I am willing to keep [shelf-stable / frozen / ready-made] foods. Suggest three simple backup meals and one short shopping list. Include allergy and food-safety reminders, but do not give medical advice.

Check it before you trust it

- Does the plan use food you will actually eat?
- Are the portions realistic for your household?
- Are the food-safety steps correct according to official guidance?
- Did it ignore an allergy or a prescribed diet?
- Is the shopping list affordable and available near you?

My safe AI use rule

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 11

Fed is the baseline

A meal plan is not a promise to become a different person. It is a small set of decisions moved to a moment when deciding is easier. Some weeks will be varied and cooked from scratch. Some weeks will be toast and frozen vegetables. Both can be fed.

The one-page takeaway

- Plan for the energy you have.
- Have zero-effort, low-effort, and some-effort options.
- Use what is already in the house.
- Keep one backup meal visible.
- Use micro-prep, not heroic prep.
- Let AI suggest; you verify food safety, allergies, and medical needs.
- Takeout and snack plates are allowed.

My next small step

GOOD TO KNOW

A final permission slip

You do not have to earn dinner by having a perfect day. You just have to make the next meal a little easier to reach.

ONE LAST THING · 11

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Pick three meals you can make without a recipe and write them on the meal map. Start with what already works; build from there.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

A system should fit your real energy, not the other way around. Keep what helps, drop what becomes another chore, and let the next small step be enough.

More life-admin printables

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.

HOME REFERENCE

The Household Command Center

The facts you need when your brain is full.

Not a perfect home binder. A small, updateable place for the information future-you will need when the lights are flickering.

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01 A household-at-a-glance page
02 A fair-share task map
03 An emergency and pet-care sheet
04 A twelve-month home admin calendar
05 A secure paper and digital index

PLAIN ENGLISH ON PURPOSE

Print it. Write on it.
Make it yours.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 12

Build the hub before the hurry

Every household runs on invisible information: which bin goes out on Tuesday, who has the plumber's number, how the cat takes his medicine, where the lease is, what to do when the power goes out. Usually one person holds it in their head. That works until they are sick, away, overwhelmed, or simply tired of being the household's only search engine.

This is a reference, not a rulebook. It is designed to be filled in gradually and stored privately. You do not need to complete every page this week.

> WATCH OUT
>
> **Keep this private**
>
> A household hub can contain addresses, phone numbers, routines, and security details. Store it in a locked drawer, a private folder, or a secure location — not on a public fridge, in a shared cloud folder, or in a screenshot you text to someone. Never write passwords, PINs, security answers, or full financial account numbers on these pages.

What belongs here

- Household contacts and local services.
- Who does which recurring tasks, and who can back them up.
- Home basics: utilities, shutoffs, maintenance, and where the manual is.
- Emergency plans and meeting points.
- Pet and plant care.
- Annual renewals and home admin dates.
- Where important documents live — a map, not a copy of everything.

What does not belong here

- Passwords or password hints.
- Bank or card numbers.
- Government ID numbers.
- Full medical records.
- Anyone's private information beyond what is needed for the household to function.
- A complete list of every possession for insurance unless you store it securely elsewhere.

The update ritual

A household hub goes stale. Once a season, check the contacts, routines, and dates. Once a year, check the insurance, emergency plan, and document locations. Put those checks in the annual home admin calendar. An out-of-date hub is still better than none, as long as you know it needs a refresh.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 12

Household at a glance

Fill in what is useful. Use a nickname or a shared note instead of a full account number. If this page will be visible to a sitter or trusted visitor, remove anything private before leaving it out.

The basics

HOME	DETAILS
Address	
Main entrance / parking note	
Wi-Fi network name (not password)	
Where the router lives	
Trash and recycling day	
Where bins are kept	
Water shutoff location	
Electrical panel location	
Gas shutoff — who to call	
Smoke and carbon monoxide alarm test month	
Where the spare key is (not if it is not safe to record)	

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 12

Key contacts

WHO	NAME	PHONE	WHEN TO CALL
Neighbour			
Landlord or property manager			
Plumber			
Electrician			
Heating / cooling			
Internet provider			
Insurance			
Vet			

House quirks

The door sticks. The extractor fan is loud. The guest bed is under the stairs. Write the things a visitor or future-you would not know.

The maintenance note

ITEM	LAST CHECKED	NEXT CHECK	WHO DOES IT

TRY THIS

Do not copy the whole house into one page

A hub is an index. If something is long — insurance policies, medical instructions, a lease — write where it lives and who to call, not the entire document again.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 12

Who does what

The mental load is not only the tasks you can see. It is noticing, planning, remembering, and reminding. A fair-share map makes those invisible tasks visible so they can be shared deliberately rather than argued about in a moment of exhaustion.

This is a practical household tool, not relationship advice. Use what helps and leave the rest.

The task map

TASK	HOW OFTEN	PRIMARY OWNER	BACKUP OWNER	WHERE THE INFO LIVES
Meal planning / food shop				
Cooking				
Dishes				
Laundry				
Cleaning shared spaces				
Trash and recycling				
Bills and mail				
Appointments				
Pet care				
Home repairs				
School or family admin				
Gifts and cards				

The noticing list

Some tasks begin with noticing, not doing. Examples: the soap is low, the fridge needs cleaning, a form is due, the pet food is almost gone. Who notices these things? Who acts on them? Who does the follow-up?

THE NOTICING TASK	WHO NOTICES	WHO ACTS	HOW WE SHARE THE LOAD

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 12

The daily and weekly minimum

Agree on a small list that keeps the household functional — not spotless. A minimum is easier to maintain than an ideal.

- ☐ Food is available.
- ☐ Trash is out when needed.
- ☐ Dishes are not growing a community.
- ☐ Essential laundry is moving.
- ☐ Pets have food, water, and care.
- ☐ One shared surface is clear.
- ☐ Medication and appointments are handled by the person who owns them.

If the primary owner is away

Write down the things the backup would need to know: the grocery login? No. The store, the usual order, the pet routine, the school contact, the calendar. Keep it to information, not passwords.

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 12

Emergency quick sheet

This page is a starting point for a household emergency plan. It is not a substitute for local emergency services or a doctor. Fill in your local numbers and check the plan with everyone who lives in the home.

WATCH OUT

Store this page safely

Do not leave a page with names, phone numbers, medical details, and security information in plain sight. Use a locked drawer or a private folder. If you make a version for a sitter, leave out anything they do not need.

In an emergency

01 Move to safety if you can.

02 Contact the local emergency number if there is immediate danger, a serious injury, fire, or a crime in progress.

03 Follow the instructions from emergency services.

04 Contact the household contact person when it is safe to do so.

05 Do not re-enter a dangerous building or try to fix a gas leak yourself.

The quick contacts

CONTACT	NAME	PHONE	NOTES
Emergency services			Local number
Non-emergency police			
Nearest hospital			
Poison control / health line			Local number
Household emergency contact			
Out-of-area contact			
Insurance emergency line			
Utility emergency line			
Vet emergency			
Building manager / landlord			

PLAIN-ENGLISH FIELD GUIDE · 12

The meeting place

WHERE WE MEET IF WE CANNOT GET BACK INSIDE | WHO CHECKS ON WHOM | WHERE THE EMERGENCY BAG LIVES

The emergency bag

- ☐ Water and a small snack.
- ☐ A flashlight and spare batteries.
- ☐ A phone charger or power bank.
- ☐ A copy of essential contacts.
- ☐ Any medication or supplies the household needs, following your own care plan.
- ☐ Pet supplies if applicable.
- ☐ A small amount of cash, if you choose to keep one.

Review the bag once a year. Replace expired items and check that the flashlight works.

What the sitter needs

Leave a short, separate page with the Wi-Fi guest access instructions only if you are comfortable, the pet routine, the emergency number, and any access details the sitter needs. Do not leave the full private hub on the counter.

The annual bag check

- ☐ Water and snacks are in date.
- ☐ The flashlight and batteries work.
- ☐ Contacts, medication, and pet supplies are current.
- ☐ Everyone knows where the bag lives.
- ☐ The meeting place is still sensible.

Date checked:

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Pets, plants, and the home-sitter page

A familiar routine is hard to explain from another city while your phone is dying. This page captures the practical care details, not the whole veterinary history.

The pet page

PET	FOOD AND TIMING	MEDICATION ROUTINE	VET AND PHONE	WHERE SUPPLIES ARE

The quirks

- The cat will not drink from the bowl next to the food.
- The dog is scared of the vacuum.
- The bird needs the cover on by 8 p.m.
- The fish tank light is on a timer.
- The pet is not allowed outside without a leash.
- The carrier is in the hall cupboard.

Write the things that matter to the animal and the sitter.

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The vet plan

QUESTION	ANSWER
Normal vet	
Emergency vet	
Insurance or payment note	
Who can approve treatment	
Where the records are	

The plant page

PLANT	WATER	LIGHT	NOTES

The sitter checklist

- ☐ Food and water locations are clear.
- ☐ The pet's routine is written down.
- ☐ The vet and emergency vet numbers are visible.
- ☐ The sitter knows what not to do.
- ☐ The alarm or key plan is agreed in advance.
- ☐ The sitter knows how to reach you and a backup.
- ☐ The trash and plant routine is clear.

GOOD TO KNOW

Medical care for pets is still medical care

If a pet is injured or unwell, contact a veterinarian. This page helps with handover; it does not replace veterinary advice.

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The annual home admin calendar

Home admin is seasonal and repetitive. Put the recurring checks in one place, then let the calendar carry the remembering. Add local dates and requirements that apply to your home.

MONTH	HOME OR ADMIN TASK	WHO	DONE
January			☐
February			☐
March			☐
April			☐
May			☐
June			☐
July			☐
August			☐
September			☐
October			☐
November			☐
December			☐

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A starter list

Use what applies. Check official local guidance for anything safety-related.

- Test smoke and carbon monoxide alarms.
- Replace alarm batteries or backup batteries.
- Check the fire extinguisher.
- Clean or replace HVAC filters.
- Check the water shutoff and know how to use it.
- Check insurance renewal and coverage.
- Check vehicle registration or inspection dates.
- Review the emergency bag.
- Update the household hub.
- Back up important digital files.
- Clear the paper “act now” folder.
- Review subscriptions and annual renewals.

The safety rule

Do not attempt repairs or maintenance that requires a qualified professional, especially gas, electrical, structural, or anything you are not trained to do. The calendar can remind you; it cannot make a dangerous job safe. Use the official utility or a licensed tradesperson.

My home admin anchor

The one recurring day I will use to check this calendar:

The task I will put in the calendar first:

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The ten-minute household reset

This is maintenance, not a deep clean. The goal is to interrupt the drift before it becomes a project. Choose one zone and one timer. Stop when the timer ends.

The reset menu

Entryway

Shoes paired or put away, rubbish out, keys in their spot, one thing returned to its room. Stop there.

Kitchen

Clear one counter, load or unload the dishwasher, wipe one surface, take out the compost or bin if full. Do not reorganise the cupboards.

Bathroom

Clear the sink, replace the toilet roll, hang the towels, take out the bathroom bin. Stop before you start scrubbing the grout.

Bedroom

Clear the bed, put one pile of clothes away, take out one glass, plug in the phone. The floor can wait.

Living space

Clear one surface, fold one blanket, take out one cup, put remotes in their place. Do not start a full declutter.

Paper landing zone

Pick up one armful, sort into act / date / file / ask / release, stop at the timer. The full triage kit has the details.

The rule of one

When the house feels impossible, do not make a list of every room. Choose the one zone that is causing the most friction: the kitchen counter before dinner, the bed before sleep, the entryway before leaving. A little friction removed from the place you use most is worth more than a perfect room you never enter.

The reset log

DATE	ZONE	WHAT CHANGED	WHAT CAN WAIT

TRY THIS

A reset is not a debt payment

You do not have to clean the whole house because the last few weeks were hard. Ten minutes today is not compensation for the past. It is a small kindness to the next hour.

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Where the important things live

An index of important documents is more useful than a pile of unsorted papers and safer than a single folder with everything in it. Record where things live, who can find them, and when they were last checked.

The document index

WHAT	WHERE IT LIVES	IS IT BACKED UP?	WHO ELSE KNOWS?	LAST CHECKED
Lease or deed				
Home and car insurance				
Identification documents				
Wills, powers of attorney, advance directives				
Tax records				
Medical and vaccination records				
Pets' records				
Warranties and manuals				
Work and pension records				
Passwords / account recovery	Use a password manager, not this sheet			

The access plan

A password manager can store the credentials; this page can store only the name of the manager, where the recovery kit lives, and who is trusted to access it in a genuine emergency. Never write the master password here.

ACCESS QUESTION	ANSWER
Which password manager do we use?	
Where is the recovery kit kept?	
Who has a legitimate emergency key?	
Where is the emergency access plan documented?	
When was it last reviewed?	

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The digital backup check

- ☐ Important documents are backed up in more than one place.
- ☐ The backup is not only on the same device.
- ☐ The family knows how to access the backup if the primary person is unavailable.
- ☐ Recovery codes are stored securely, not in the same folder as the account.
- ☐ The plan has been checked in the last year.

The loss or theft page

If a wallet, phone, or documents are lost or stolen, use official provider websites and phone numbers. You may need to contact the police, your bank, the identity document issuer, and your insurer. Do not share passwords or one-time codes with anyone who contacts you claiming to help. Record the reference numbers somewhere secure.

My backup plan

WHAT	COPY ONE	COPY TWO	LAST CHECKED

My update check

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A small hub is enough

The household will not become calm because one binder exists. It may become a little easier because the plumber’s number is not in your head, because the pet routine is written down, and because the person who usually handles everything has somewhere to point.

The one-page takeaway

- Keep the hub private.
- Record where things live, not every private detail.
- Never write passwords or full account numbers.
- Make invisible tasks visible.
- Put annual checks in the calendar.
- Update the hub slowly; a partial hub is useful.

My next small step

GOOD TO KNOW

A final permission slip

A household does not need a perfect manager. It needs enough shared information that one tired person is not the only place the answers live.

ONE LAST THING · 12

Use one thing. Then keep it.

Fill in only the household basics today — names, key contacts, and where the important documents live. Store the finished pages somewhere private, not on a public fridge.

MY NEXT SMALL STEP

THE RULE FOR THIS HALF OF THE PACK

A system should fit your real energy, not the other way around. Keep what helps, drop what becomes another chore, and let the next small step be enough.

More life-admin printables

- 07 The Low-Energy Weekly Reset
- 08 The Paper Pile Triage Kit
- 09 Bills, Renewals & Subscriptions
- 10 The Appointment Companion
- 11 The Low-Energy Meal Plan

Free to use

Print these for yourself, your classroom, or a client. Please keep the credit and don't resell the files.

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Keep the useful part. Leave the rest.